



Hindustan Times

Meta to report child abuse cases to govt

Sejal Sharma

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NEW DELHI: Meta will report cases of child sexual abuse and other child-safety concerns directly to the cybercrime portal run by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Union home ministry, a Meta spokesperson and officials at the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) told HT.

The decision follows a BBC Eye investigation in July that found advertisements on Instagram using explicit terms to direct users to Telegram channels allegedly selling child sexual abuse material (CSAM). MeitY summoned Meta officials after the findings came to light, and the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR), the country's apex child rights body, separately took suo motu cognisance and opened an enquiry into the

Govt expands scrutiny of content

WHERE META REPORTS CHILD ABUSE CASES

Before: To US-based child protection agency
Now: Also directly to the home ministry's cybercrime portal

July BBC Eye finds Instagram ads leading to Telegram channels allegedly selling child sexual abuse material; IT ministry summons Meta

Sept 9 Child rights body NCPCR summons Meta India MD Arun Srinivas

Sept 16 Second summons

THE LAW

Section 19, Pocso Act: Anyone aware of an offence against a child must inform police. NCPCR asked why Meta did not, after allegedly learning of the ads

Next: NCPCR drafting voluntary platform code on age checks, recommendation algorithms

company.

"Protecting children on our platforms is a priority for us and we are committed to working with the government to ensure that the perpetrators of these crimes are held responsible. To collectively strengthen our efforts to combat this harm, Meta will now report child

safety matters directly to the Cyber crime portal managed by I4C," the spokesperson said.

A senior MeitY official said Meta informed the government of its decision in a letter about a week ago. The official did not share the letter with HT.

Meta has so far reported

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COURT BLOCKS TRUMP MOVE TO LIMIT STUDENT VISA STAY IN U.S.

Shashank Mattoo

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WASHINGTON: In another immigration-related legal setback for the Trump administration, a US court has blocked the government's attempt to tighten visa requirements on how long foreign students, exchange visitors and foreign journalists can study or work in America.

The new visa rules were set to go into effect on September 15, before Monday's court order postponed the date pending further legal proceedings. The successful challenge to the visa restrictions was filed by an alliance of groups of educators and unions.

Foreign students are presently allowed to remain in the United States legally so long as they maintain their student status, known as "duration of status". The Trump administration's new rules would have terminated the earlier policy and favoured a strict four-year student visa.

→P11

RIDE-HAILING APP RAPIDO FINED ₹10L, TOLD TO REMOVE HIGHER FARE NUDGE

Pallavi Singhal

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NEW DELHI: Ride-booking apps that prompt users to pay more while the app is still searching for a driver will now have to stop using such nudges. The Central Consumer Protection Authority has imposed a ₹10 lakh penalty on Roppen Transportation Services Pvt Ltd, which operates Rapido, and directed the firm to stop using designs that could steer riders towards higher payments.

→P11

BENGAL BYPOLL: BJP FIELDS MOTHER OF SUVENDU'S P.A. KILLED IN MAY

KOLKATA: The Bharatiya Janata Party has fielded Hasirani Rath — mother of West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari's aide who was killed in May — from Nandigram in the October 6 by-election. Chandranath Rath was shot dead in North 24 Parganas district on May 6, two days after the BJP swept the state assembly polls. The bypoll was necessitated after Adhikari, who won from two seats in the 2026 polls, gave up Nandigram.

→P5

2 KUKI WOMEN KILLED IN FRESH ETHNIC VIOLENCE IN MANIPUR

Thomas Ngangom

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IMPHAL: Two women from the Kuki community were gunned down allegedly by armed miscreants in a village in Manipur's Tamenglong district on Tuesday, two days after four civilians from the community were shot dead in the district amid the ongoing ethnic violence in the state. Police said the accused are yet to be identified.

→P5

Saudi issues slew of alerts as Houthis step up attacks

Reuters

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RIYADH/DUBAI: Saudi Arabia issued security alerts over a range of territory on Tuesday, including in the holy city of Mecca and second-largest city Jeddah, following a week of attacks from Iran-aligned fighters that have drawn it deeper into the Middle East war.

The alerts were swiftly lifted and Saudi authorities did not immediately report whether any incoming projectiles had landed, nor was there any immediate claim of responsibility for attacks.

But the alerts were the widest ranging since an escalation in the conflict last week, and the alarm in Mecca was the first of the war in the city, which houses shrines sacred to all Muslims.

The Iran-aligned Houthis in

Oil tankers earn \$1mn a day as war sparks ship shortage

The cost of hiring an oil tanker on the industry's benchmark trade route topped \$1 million a day for the first time, as the Iran war leaves too few ships willing to cross the Strait of Hormuz to collect cargoes.

Vessels hauling oil from inside the Persian Gulf to China were being hired at \$1.035 million a day, accord-

ing to data from the Baltic Exchange in London on Monday. The benchmark route has become less relevant during the war because the main means of exporting Persian Gulf oil has shifted to shutting barrels through Hormuz for collection just outside by tankers that don't want to navigate the strait.

BLOOMBERG

continued on →9

Delhi to build hostel rooms for 10k college students: CM Gupta

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will build hostels to provide accommodation to 10,000 students studying in colleges and universities in the Capital, chief minister Rekha Gupta announced on Tuesday, as a new high-powered committee began work on addressing the shortage of student housing and regulating private paying guest (PG) facilities.

Gupta said hostels would be constructed through various government departments, with land acquired wherever necessary. The facilities will cater to both male and female students. "They should have access to a



Rekha Gupta

safe and comfortable environment so that they can fully focus on their studies, their future and their dreams," Gupta said.

The announcement comes days after the collapse of a multi-storey PG accommodation building in Satya Niketan, which killed seven people, including five DU students.

HC JUNKS ITAT'S SEVEN 'RECKLESS' COMMON ORDERS IN PATANJALI CASES

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court has set aside seven orders passed by the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal in cross-appeals involving Patanjali Ayurved Limited, criticising the manner in which the matters were disposed of and describing the proceedings as a "shocking picture" of procedural lapses and a lack of transparency.

The bench, in its September 10 judgment uploaded on September 15, took serious exception to the ITAT passing a common order in all seven matters, which comprised separate appeals filed by Patanjali Ayurved Limited and the Revenue Department, despite different dates having been fixed for pronouncement of orders in the two sets of appeals.

→P2

{ KAILASH HILLS MURDER }

Delhi doc killed help as she did not clean his clinic: Cops reject 'mental illness' claim in charge sheet

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NEW DELHI: A 50-year-old dermatologist allegedly killed his domestic help after becoming enraged that she only prioritised his wife's instructions over his demands that she clean his clinic, the Delhi Police said in a charge sheet filed on Monday in the June murder in southeast Delhi's Kailash Hills, rejecting his initial defence of a "mental-health history".

The 340-page chargesheet was filed before Saket judicial magistrate first class Deepika Thakran, with the matter to be considered



The accused, Manish Gupta (above) ran a clinic in Kailash Hills.

HT PHOTOS

for cognisance on September 18.

Manish Gupta, who ran a dermatology clinic adjoining his flat at Mount Kailash Apartments,

was arrested on June 18 for allegedly beating and murdering his 45-year-old domestic help, Meena Halder. The chargesheet,

a copy of which has been seen by HT, said Gupta was unhappy with Halder for some time and repeatedly asked his wife to dismiss her.

"His wife continued to retain Halder because of their long association and emotional bond... accused felt Halder refused to listen to him and only gave preference to his wife's instructions," police said.

To substantiate this allegation, police recorded the statement of Halder's son, who allegedly told investigators that "his mother had complained that Gupta was frequently dissatisfied with her work and often scolded her".

NUMBER THEORY

Superpower vs retaining power: Trump's dilemma



By Roshan Kishore

Less than two months from now, Donald Trump will face the most important political challenge of his second presidency – the mid-term elections in the US. Irrespective of what happens in the elections, things are pretty bad for him on the economic front. Crude oil and fuel prices have risen sharply, 10-year US bond yields crossed the psychological 5% threshold on Monday and hit a two-decade high on Tuesday. The Federal Reserve is expected to increase interest rates later today. At the root of these problems is Trump's inability to reconcile his idea of acting as the superpower (head of US) and retaining power.

1 Some of US economy's recent problems predate Trump's second Presidency

On Wednesday night, the US Federal Reserve will announce interest rates. Markets widely expect the central bank to increase interest rates, something which Trump has been publicly speaking against, intruding into what is seen as the realm of an independent monetary policy in the US. Personal consumption expenditure inflation has been above the US Fed's mandated target of 2% for 65 months now, a streak that began amid pandemic-era fiscal stimulus and supply-chain disruptions but has persisted long after those initial pressures eased. The Federal Reserve raised its benchmark interest rate by 5.25 percentage points between March 2022 and July 2023, one of its sharpest tightening cycles in decades, putting upward pressure on retail borrowing costs such as mortgage rates. Although the Fed has cut rates since the end of 2024, borrowing costs remained elevated and could rise further, something Trump believes could hurt him politically.

Policy rate and inflation in the US (Numbers in percent)

Date	Federal Funds Target Range - Upper Limit (%)	CPI (%)
Jan '09	0.25	-0.1
Feb '09	0.25	-0.1
Mar '20	0.25	0.2
Feb '22	8.75	8.5
Jan '26	3.4	3.4
Aug '26	3.75	3.75

Source: BLS, FRED

2 Trump's West Asia misadventure has really worsened things

The immediate macroeconomic situation in the US would not have been so unfavourable had Trump not started a war in West Asia. Post-pandemic inflation had been coming down gradually until February 2026 when it came in at 2.4%. On 28 February, the US and Israel launched a war against Iran and the latter managed to successfully shut maritime traffic in the Strait of Hormuz, effectively choking energy supplies from the Persian Gulf. This gave a fillip to energy prices and overall inflation once again and US inflation climbed to 4.2% by May 2026. While it came down to 3.4% in August, it could rise again given the record surge in retail fuel prices in the past couple of weeks, following attacks by Iran-backed Houthi rebels effecting a large disruption to Saudi oil supplies from the Red Sea. Yields on 10-year-US-treasuries have also surged above the critical 5% threshold in the past couple of days; they had gone below the 4%-mark after a long time just before the Iran war started. All this has added to inflation and also increased pressure on the Fed to hike rates.

10-year yield on US Treasury Bills (Numbers in percent)

Date	10-year yield (%)
Jan 2025	4.56
Feb 2026	4.0
Sep 2026	5.01

Data for 15 Sep, 2026 for 7 pm IST
Source: investing.com

3 And made America's longer-term economic challenges more difficult

The immediate obsession with interest rates, fuel prices, bond yields and Trump's political theatrics against the technocrats managing these things notwithstanding, the US has a longer-term economic problem. This is the growing unsustainability of the fiscal trajectory of the world's largest economy, which is running higher deficits and adding to its debt at a rapid pace. The root of this problem is to be found in the higher spending on populist programmes and tax-cuts both of which are rooted in political populism, which the likes of Trump have only encouraged. Trump's latest announcement of giving every American adult \$5,000 if the Republican Party were to win the mid-term is another such fiscal misadventure.

Key Projections in Congressional Budget Office's Baseline

(US's fiscal situation is expected to worsen going forward)

	Total revenues	Total outlays	Debt held by the public at the end of the period
2026	17.5	23.3	101.0
2027	17.7	23.3	102.0
2028–2031	17.6	23.4	110.0
2032–2036	17.7	24.1	120.0
2037–2046	18.1	25.3	144.0
2047–2056	18.6	27.1	175.0

Numbers in percent of GDP. Multi-year period values are averages. Data presented supplements CBO's February 2026 report The Budget and Economic Outlook: 2026 to 2036. Source: www.cbo.gov

A sensible political strategy, from Trump's perspective, would have been to focus on bringing down inflation in the US which would have allowed him to enjoy political tailwinds from lower interest rates. Tariffs were a bad idea to begin with. Whether he was hoodwinked into believing – perhaps by the Israeli regime and his lateral entry advisors rather than the US's traditional intelligence apparatus – that the Iranian regime would collapse in a matter of days and the war would not cause any large inflationary pressures is now a matter of counter-factual debate. The war's economic effects are already affecting

the US and the rest of the world. Even if Trump were to decide to end hostilities by forcing the Israelis into agreeing to it, it would entail a significant loss of US power in the West Asian region. If he were to decide to let things go on like they are, he risks losing significant political capital at home. The world is facing the consequences of an American president who has fallen between the two stools of the US acting as a global superpower and its leader trying to retain political power at home. This contradiction is also testing countries such as India, which is what the second part of this series will discuss.



Hindustan Times

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ROAD RAGE CASE: DRIVER HELD IN RAJ; BOOKED FOR MURDER ATTEMPT

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GURUGRAM: The driver who allegedly rammed his car into a woman motorcyclist on Gurugram's Golf Course Road on Sunday was arrested on Tuesday, police said, adding that attempt-to-murder charges were invoked after investigators concluded that the road-rage incident appeared to involve a deliberate attempt to hit the biker.

The suspects were identified as 33-year-old Kalyan Bainsla and his cousin, 34-year-old Lavish. Investigators said Kalyan attempted to escape from custody while being brought back to Gurugram.

MAN HELD FOR ASSAULTING FATHER OF CJP PROTESTER GETS INTERIM BAIL

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NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Tuesday granted three weeks of interim bail to self-styled influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj, who is accused of assaulting a man during the Jantar Mantar protests in July, but expressed concern over his conduct on social media, noting that he showed "a tendency to boast about the incident" rather than showing any "remorse".

On the defence's concern over the safety of the complainant and his minor daughter, the court barred Bhardwaj from contacting them, their family or prosecution witnesses.

Above ₹2,000, UPI no longer free of charge for sellers

mint

Anshika Kayastha
and Harsh Kumar

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MUMBAI/NEW DELHI: The finance ministry on Tuesday announced that a 0.4% merchant discount rate (MDR) will apply to person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000, while person-to-person (P2P) transactions will remain free irrespective of their value.

For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction, the ministry said in a statement. The announcement brings to a close months of discussions over charges for higher-value UPI transactions. It also ends a six-year zero-MDR regime that sought to promote digital payments but was criticised by banks as inviable.

The new framework follows the government's notification on Monday keeping UPI transactions of up to ₹2,000 and RuPay debit card payments free of MDR, with banks and payment system providers barred from imposing direct or indirect charges on such transactions.

The notification follows an amendment to section 10 A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, which provides an enabling framework for imposing an MDR on notified

How the charges will work

₹5 On UPI payments above ₹2,000 in specified merchant categories such as railways, telecom services, insurance, and fuel.

0.4% On P2M UPI transactions above ₹2,000, capped at ₹300 per transaction. For payments of ₹75,000 and above, cap will be ₹300.

0.02% On capital market transactions, capped at ₹300 per transaction.

NO CHARGE Person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions up to ₹2,000. All person-to-person transactions.

THE EXEMPTIONS

- Small merchants operating under the person-to-person merchant (P2PM) framework. This category supports small vendors receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month through UPI QR payments directly into their bank accounts.
- UPI autopay/mandates — utility bills, OTT payments and recurring investments.

EFFECTIVE FROM OCTOBER 15

electronic payment modes. The amendment Bill was passed by Parliament during the Monsoon Session.

Only 4% of merchant transactions will be affected by the introduction of MDR, according to the statement, as most transactions either fall below the ₹2,000 threshold or qualify for zero MDR under the P2PM framework for small merchants.

"P2P transactions constitute 37% of the total UPI transactions in volume terms and 70% in value terms," the finance ministry said in a release. It added that the decision followed deliberations by NPCI's UPI steering committee on operational parameters, fee distribution

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'GOV'T SURRENDERING TO U.S. PRESSURE': OPPN SLAMS MDR

The Congress on Tuesday accused the government of breaking its own promise of keeping the UPI free of fees after a notification issued the day before paved the way for a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charge on UPI transactions above ₹2,000. Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul, Gandhi said the move breaks the government's promise of a free UPI system, and accused it of "surrendering to American pressure". "Modi government's loot has now reached UPI," Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge said. "No fees on UPI" has been changed to "no fees on UPI transactions up to ₹2,000." →P9

SUSPEND SCHOOL SPORTS IN DELHI, NCR: CAQM AHEAD OF YEARLY AIR MESS

Jasjeev Gandhiok

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NEW DELHI: The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) has issued an advisory to the state governments of Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, asking them to ensure no physical sports activities or sports competitions take place at schools during November and December, due to the air quality situation at that time of the year.

CAQM has referred to directions issued by the Supreme Court in the 'MC Mehta vs Union of India' case. The SC last year expressed concern regarding the impact of severe air quality on children participating in physical sports competitions.

INDIA, CHINA MUST BE SENSITIVE TO 'CORE ISSUES', PM TOLD XI AT BRICS

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi emphasised India's concerns at his meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping and made it clear that both sides should show sensitivity to each other's "core" issues, the external affairs ministry said on Tuesday against the backdrop of efforts to normalise bilateral ties.

Modi and Xi met on the margins of the Brics Summit in New Delhi on September 12 when the Chinese leader travelled to India for the first time in seven years. The Indian side emphasised that peace and tranquillity in the border areas would be the "essential

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Pellet guns among key focus areas for SC panel

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed its five-member high-powered enquiry committee (HPEC) to begin its probe into the July protests by examining the use of pellet guns, targeted violence and harassment of female protesters, injuries sustained by police personnel and destruction of property, while making clear that broader constitutional questions arising from the July protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) will be decided by the court itself.

In a detailed order issued after the September 10 hearing, a bench comprising Chief Justice of

continued on →2



Panel's remit sharpened

The panel has been asked, "in the first instance", to examine:

- Use of pellet guns
- Targeted violence and harassment of female protesters
- Injuries sustained by police personnel
- Excessive violence and destruction of property

SC TO CONSIDER CONSTITUTIONAL QUESTIONS

The order is a significant sharpening of the mandate given to the HPEC by the court on August 18. The court reiterated that wider constitutional questions, including the use of facial recognition by the law enforcement agencies, would remain for its own consideration "at the appropriate stage".



{ GRAHAM STAINES MURDER }

Odisha rejects Dara Singh's release plea

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BHUBANESWAR: Odisha's State Sentence Review Board has rejected a plea for premature release by Dara Singh, serving life imprisonment for the 1999 murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two young sons, ending months of uncertainty over his remission plea.

The board's decision comes ahead of the next hearing in Supreme Court on September 17, and after multiple prompts from the apex court. The board, which considered the case at its special meeting on August 31 said Singh's



Dara Singh

release could have "societal ramifications" and potentially lead to communal disturbances in the area. Singh, 67, has spent more than 26 years in prison and became eligible for consideration for premature release under Odisha's remission guidelines. →P5

INDIA'S TRADE DEFICIT NARROWS AS EXPORTS RISE 26% IN AUGUST

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NEW DELHI: India's merchandise exports in August logged an annualised growth of over 26% to \$43.81 billion, outpacing about 14% growth in imports at \$70.67 billion and narrowing the trade deficit on the back of policy measures such as trade diversification, bilateral deals and curbs on unproductive imports of commodities like gold.

Commerce secretary Rajesh Agrawal said, "Export growth momentum [has] accelerated further in August." Experts said one of the key reasons for the trade deficit narrowing was a sharp fall in gold imports this August. →P12

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{ MY INDIA } 'DEROGATORY REMARKS'

DMK leaders booked for comments on CM

Tamil Nadu Police has booked leaders of the opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), including party deputy general secretary and former Union minister A Raja, and former state minister P K Sekar Babu, over alleged derogatory remarks against chief minister Vijay and his cabinet colleague CTR Nimal Kumar during a recent party event, officials said on Tuesday. A case against DMK MLA Vasantham Karthikeyan over his comments against the chief minister was also filed by Kallakurichi police. DMK slammed the move. Party spokesperson TKS Elangovan said, "As an opposition party we have the right to criticise the ruling party for their mistakes. This government is only working against DMK." HTC

{ MY INDIA } IN 4 DISTRICTS

WB stops Akshaya Patra mid-day meals

The West Bengal government has withdrawn the approval given to ISKCON-linked Akshaya Patra Foundation to serve mid-day meals in state-run schools in four districts. "It was a policy decision," said a senior official of the education department. The nod was granted to the organisation in August, months after the BJP came to power in the state. "We understand the decision was made after much deliberation and we respect the same. We appreciate the steps taken by WB government to strengthen PM POSHAN program," Bharatarshabha Dasa, national president, Akshaya Patra Foundation, said. HTC

{ MY INDIA } BOMB HOAX MAIL NETWORK

Cops to question Google as 513k fake Gmail IDs traced

The Gujarat police will question Google over a lack of safeguards after smashing a criminal network that set up and managed more than 500,000 fake Gmail accounts to send hoax bomb threats to government offices, an officer said on Tuesday. Police in Gujarat cracked an email network this week they said was at the helm of sending inter-state bomb threats and arrested two people, uncovering 513,847 Gmail IDs and passwords being used since 2022. "We will write to Google, ask them to make some policy changes so (safeguards) cannot be bypassed," Bheda said, adding that police planned to formally designate Google as a subject of the investigation soon. HTC

{ MY DELHI } 2 DAYS OF DELAYS

Dubai-Delhi SpiceJet late by several hours

Three SpiceJet flights from Delhi to Dubai were delayed over two straight days, stranding hundreds at Delhi airport and prompting protests. Flight SG-5111, scheduled to depart Delhi at 7:45am on Monday with 130 passengers, was eventually pushed to 2pm on Tuesday. Boarding for the flight began on Tuesday. Another flight, SG-5015, scheduled to depart at 6:45pm on Monday with around 160 passengers, was also rescheduled multiple times. Its departure was finally revised to 6pm on Tuesday. A third flight, SG-9511, scheduled for 8:30am on Tuesday, was rescheduled to 9:30pm. It had not taken off till 11am. HTC

{ MY INDIA } GRAFT CASE

SC denies relief to suspended PB DIG

The Supreme Court on Tuesday told suspended Punjab Police DIG Harcharan Singh Bhullar that his bail plea in a corruption case deserves to be dismissed even as it adjourned the matter by four weeks to await the examination of key witnesses in the case. A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana observed, "It is 100% case of dismissal," as Bhullar's lawyer pointed out gaps in the prosecution case as it failed to examine a material witness and sought permission of the court to allow two other witnesses to be examined in the trial. It said, "You want a dismissal now or later... We will examine your plea after certain witnesses are examined." HTC

HC junks 7 'reckless' common orders by ITAT in Patanjali case

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court has set aside seven orders passed by the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (ITAT) in cross-appeals involving Patanjali Ayurved Limited, criticising the manner in which the matters were disposed of and describing the proceedings as a "shocking picture" of procedural lapses and a lack of transparency.

A bench comprising justices Dinesh Mehta and Rajneesh Kumar Gupta, in its September 10 judgment uploaded on September 15, took serious exception to the ITAT passing a common order in all seven matters, which comprised separate appeals filed by Patanjali Ayurved Limited and the Revenue Department, despite different dates having been fixed for pronouncement of orders in the two sets of appeals.

The ITAT, the court said, neither addressed the contentions raised by the assessee nor examined the issues involved in the appeals, and proceeded to dispose of all seven matters through an order comprising fewer than seven paragraphs.

The court further observed that the Members had displayed "undue haste, rather recklessness" in passing and signing the order, while the tribunal staff also failed to bring the errors to their attention at the time of signing. It held that such negligence could not be countenanced, particularly from appellate authorities occupying

the highest rung of the fact-finding appellate hierarchy.

"These appeals portray a rather shocking picture of the procedural lapses and opaqueness in which the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (hereinafter referred to as 'the Tribunal'), the highest fact-finding body, has been passing the orders in a zeal rather over-anxiety of disposing the cases. We are not much concerned with the size of the order but what shocks us is, the non-application of mind and undue haste which learned Members of the Tribunal have exhibited," the court said.

It added, "On perusal of the impugned order, we are unable to comprehend anything out of it, as it is bereft of any logic, reasoning or rationale behind it. It is therefore clear that the learned Members have shown undue haste rather recklessness while passing and signing the order, and even their staff failed to bring it to notice of the learned Members while getting the order signed."

It also took note of a discrepancy in the hearing and pronouncement dates. Four appeals were recorded as having been heard and pronounced on August 6, 2025, while the common order also dealt with three revenue appeals shown as heard and pronounced on August 13, 2025.

The court passed the orders while dealing with appeals filed by the Income Tax commissioner against the ITAT's August 6 and 13 orders quashing the assessment proceedings against Patanjali and allowing its appeals.

'Widow's Bay' wave sweeps Emmys

Widow's Bay, a horror comedy about a cursed US town, led the Emmy Award winners with a record 14 statuettes including best comedy, while emergency room drama The Pitt repeated as best drama at television's highest honors



78th EMMYS AWARDS

BEST COMEDY ACTOR: Matthew Rhys, *Widow's Bay*BEST COMEDY ACTRESS: Jean Smart, *Hacks*BEST DRAMA ACTRESS: Rhea Seehorn, *Pluribus*BEST DRAMA ACTOR: Noah Wyle, *The Pitt*BEST DRAMA SERIES: *The Pitt*BEST LIMITED OR ANTHOLOGY SERIES: *DTF St. Louis***Horror-comedy steals the show**

Widow's Bay unequivocally owned the night and broke the comedy series record set last year by "The Studio" when it won 13. The show leans into comedy and horror as it tells the story of a New England island community reckoning with a centuries-old curse.



14 Awards Won

JEAN'S ACTING SMARTS

Hacks star Jean Smart won her fifth Emmy for portraying tenacious stand-up comic Deborah Vance. She is the first to win the Emmy for best comedy actress for every season of a show's run. Julia Louis-Dreyfus, who won best comedy actress for six of the seven seasons of "Veep," is the only woman to come close to Smart's milestone.



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{ JANTAR MANTAR PROTESTS PROBE }

SC tells panel to focus on pellet guns, violence against women, cops' injuries

→CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

India Surya Kant and justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana also directed the committee to ensure protection and confidentiality for vulnerable witnesses, including keeping their identities undisclosed, and said a separate online portal could be created to enable them to submit evidence and documents.

The court's latest directions give the HPEC a specific priority list as it begins its inquiry into the competing allegations surrounding the July 20 protests. The committee has been asked, "in the first instance", to examine four sets of issues — use of pellet guns; targeted violence and harassment of female protesters; injuries sustained by police personnel; and excessive violence and destruction of property "occasioned on either side".

The order is a significant sharpening of the mandate given to the HPEC by the court on August 18. While the committee will examine the factual allegations and assist the court, the Supreme Court reiterated that wider constitutional questions arising from the controversy, including the use of facial recognition by law enforcement agencies, would remain for its own consideration "at the appropriate stage".

The court also rejected a plea by some petitioners for reconstruction of the HPEC, expressing "some measure of disquiet" over what it called "conjecture and pre-conceived notions" against the committee even before it had commenced its inquiry.

The HPEC, the bench said, had been constituted to assist the Supreme Court "with the highest standards of fairness and transparency and with a dispassionate approach" and was not meant to espouse the cause of either side.

The order also emphasised the protection of vulnerable witnesses in view of allegations of threats and intimidation surrounding the protests.

In a separate direction, the bench ordered Delhi Police to assess the threat perception of a 14-year-old female protester and provide protection to her and her family. It also directed the police to expeditiously investigate allegations that anti-social elements had threatened or harassed the girl and her family and submit a status report before the next hearing. The order recorded allegations that threats had been made to the life of the child and her family and that no action had been taken by Delhi Police against those allegedly responsible.

The Supreme Court had already expressed concern during last week's hearing over the treatment of the minor, saying allegations of intimidation of a child could not simply await the outcome of the HPEC inquiry if those accused were free to threaten or browbeat the victim and her family.

The intervention came amid a criminal case against right-wing influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj, who was recently detained after allegedly claiming in an interview that he had "cracked the skull" of the father of a student activist — the minor referred to by the bench on



The July 20 march to Parliament by protesting students came weeks after the agitation against the NEET paper leaks. HT PHOTO

Thursday, during an earlier CJP protest. Delhi Police subsequently invoked provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and criminal intimidation in the case relating to the alleged assault on the 38-year-old man.

A separate Pcoso case was also registered against Bhardwaj following allegations by the student that she was subjected to rape threats, abuse and circulation of morphed images after she complained about the alleged assault on her father.

The latest order goes further in creating a framework for witnesses appearing before the committee. It said statements and evidence submitted by vulnerable witnesses must be kept strictly confidential and their identities protected. The HPEC may create a separate online portal to facilitate the submission of documents and evidence by such witnesses and other stakeholders.

The court also appointed senior advocate Dr Monika Gusain,

recommendations but could not order registration of FIRs, since the power to direct a criminal investigation remained with the Supreme Court.

The clarification followed the court's September 1 decision to use its extraordinary powers under Article 142 to bring criminal proceedings arising from the protests to an end. FIRs registered between July 20 and 25 in connection with the protests were ordered not to be pursued or investigated, and the court directed that no fresh FIRs be registered in relation to those incidents.

The HPEC's fact-finding exercise will therefore proceed within a framework in which the Supreme Court has retained control over any decision to order criminal investigation while asking the committee to focus first on the allegations it considers most pressing.

The matter will next come up on October 9.

The July 20 march to Parliament by protesting students came weeks after the agitation against leaks in the NEET test paper that necessitated a retest began; the protests, catalysed and headed by the Cockroach Janata Party, also demanded the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The government eventually gave in to the demands; Pradhan resigned on July 25. The government also set up a committee headed by Infosys chairman Nandan Nilekani to reform the test process and launched efforts to strengthen the test conducting agency NTA.

Prez yet to okay UCC bills passed in Assam, Guj, MP

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NEW DELHI: The President is yet to approve the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) bills passed by the state assemblies of Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh earlier this year.

On September 13, Union home minister, Amit Shah, promised that all National Democratic Alliance (NDA) ruled states will have a UCC in place before 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

Uttarakhand was the first state to implement a state-specific UCC on January 27, 2025, ten months after the President's approval. In the interregnum it drafted exhaustive rules that defined powers of different set of officials for implementation of the law. The President's approval of the draft UCC law came 32 days after the bill was passed in the state assembly on February 7, 2024.

This year, three Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) ruled states, Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh assemblies have approved the UCC bills, similar to the one implemented in Uttarakhand with changes specific to the state's tribal communities and customs.

The Gujarat assembly passed the UCC bill on March 24, 2026, and referred it to governor the following week. "The bill has been reserved and referred to the President by the Governor. We are hopeful that it will be soon approved," a Gujarat government official said.

Soon after coming back to power in this summer assembly polls, the Assam assembly passed the UCC on May 27 with

AMONG OTHER BJP STATES, RAJASTHAN Tabled the UCC BILL IN THE ASSEMBLY ON AUGUST 21 BUT IT IS YET TO BE TAKEN UP FOR DISCUSSION

the draft bill prepared in about 10 days. The Assam UCC bill excluded scheduled tribes, which comprise 12.45% of the population in the state. "The bill has been sent for President's approval. We are waiting for the response," a senior government official said.

In Madhya Pradesh, the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill was passed in the legislative assembly on July 21 and the following day it was sent for President's approval, according to officials familiar with the matter. "We are waiting for the President's nod and we are confident of getting the approval soon," a General Administration Department (GAD) official said.

The UCC has long figured in the BJP's manifesto, making up a troika along with the construction of a Ram Temple in Ayodhya, and the abrogation of Article 370. The other two promises have been fulfilled and the BJP has figured out that getting individual states to pass UCC bills is the way to fulfil the third.

However, NDA allies such as Janata Dal (United), the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), and the Lok Janshakti Party, are not very comfortable with the UCC plan.

JD (U) working president, Sanjay Jha, on Monday said that the party would speak to home minister Shah on UCC implementation. TDP spokesperson Lavu Sri Krishna Devarayalu, said the party will discuss the issue with all stakeholders when the time will come. Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) Chirag Paswan said his party was committed to "uniformity and diversity" within Constitutional framework.

The BJP's alliance partners in Nagaland and Meghalaya have opposed UCC's implementation. In January 2025, Meghalaya chief minister, Conrad Sangma, had said that UCC was neither "appropriate nor practical" for a diverse country like India. He, however, acknowledged that certain aspects of civil laws can be made uniform. Nagaland chief minister Neiphiu Rio had sought exemption for Nagaland from UCC and said in September 2023 that UCC can threaten unique Naga culture and customs.

Among other BJP ruled states, the Rajasthan government tabled the UCC Bill in the Assembly on August 21 but it is yet to be taken up for discussion. The Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra governments have constituted expert panels to finalise a state specific UCC draft. Odisha is in the process of constituting a committee to draft a UCC law. West Bengal has announced that it will soon have a law for Uniform Civil Code. The BJP government in Uttar Pradesh has promised UCC if it comes back to power in 2027.

(With inputs from state bureaus)

My BENGALURU

Fake drug racket probe widens

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BENGALURU: The first clue in Karnataka's suspected fake drug racket was found not in a hospital or pharmacy, but in a field.

A labourer in CK Tandya village near Dodderi in Ramana-gara district noticed discarded medicine waste, including vials, tubes and packets containing some powder. He alerted a police constable, who visited the area, collected samples and passed the information to senior officers.

The tip led investigators on August 18 to an unlicensed facility at Kurubakeranahalli, near the Bidadi toll gate. They seized medicines worth ₹4.91 crore, along with expired stock, injection filling equipment, packaging material and forged labels, superintendent of police, Ramanagarar district, R Srinivas Gowda said. Investigators suspected that cheaper medicines were being transferred into fresh vials and relabelled as expensive pharmaceutical brands. The biggest seizure comprised 5,640 vials labelled as Cefivigent 2.5 injections, which police said was priced at ₹3.38 crore.

"Some of the injectable antibiotics recovered are used against serious bacterial infections, including pneumonia, complicated urinary and abdominal infections and infections involving drug resistant bacteria," a health department official said.

Four people were arrested in the first operation: Venkatesh, proprietor of Bangalore Special Life in Chamrajpet; Tejas, the warehouse manager and a relative of R Prashant; and workers Prabhudeva Gowda and Naveen Kumar, the SP said.

The equipment and labels provided investigators with an initial picture of the alleged operation.

Officials suspected that medicines were being transferred into new vials, relabelled and returned to the pharmaceutical supply chain. Medicines bought for around ₹600 to ₹700 a vial were allegedly sold for several thousand rupees after relabelling.

The scale of the seizure led to a warning by Health and Family Welfare Minister U T Khader: "If one day we get almost ₹5 crore worth of fake drugs, I wonder how many crores worth of fake drugs are already among people."

Investigators began tracing the medicines to Telangana and Himachal Pradesh, where cheaper formulations were allegedly procured before being brought into Karnataka.

Khader wrote to Union Health Minister J P Nadda seeking assistance from central agencies, while Karnataka constituted a six member Special Investigation Team headed by Joint Commissioner of Police (West) C Vamshikrishna.

By end of August, officials were examining whether the suspected medicines had reached intensive care units



Since the value of the seized drugs exceeds ₹5 crore, the Centre may also order a CBI probe

UT KHADER, Health minister

and been administered to patients. There was no confirmation at that stage that the seized medicines had been given to patients.

Investigators also began following purchase records, sales vouchers, batch numbers and bank transactions. Searches eventually extended to more than 10 locations across Karnataka, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra.

R Prashant, a medical representative linked to the Bidadi premises, emerged as a key accused and suspected kingpin, according to police. Investigators later learnt that he had left India for Azerbaijan, they added.

The inquiry took another turn on September 11, when the SIT and Drugs Control Department raided Krupa Healthcare near Minerva Circle in Bengaluru. Its owner, licensed pharmacist Veeresh Kumar Jain, was arrested.

Officials seized suspected counterfeit medicines, financial records and supply documents.

Investigators suspected that the premises had been used to store medicines before their distribution to medical shops, hospitals and clinics.

The second investigation revealed the expanded scale of the racket.

Investigators identified suspected counterfeit cancer medicines, ICU injections and other lifesaving drugs. The individual names of the suspected counterfeit cancer medicines have not been publicly identified.

Some medicines were allegedly sold at discounts of about 50%, while investigators also suspected that expired medicines were being placed in new containers and fitted with labels resembling those of established pharmaceutical companies.

The suspected distribution network was believed to have reached more than 90 hospitals and clinics in Bengaluru, while more than 15 medical representatives came under scrutiny.

By September 12, investigators were following the financial trail alongside the move-

ment of medicines.

Investigators were also examining links between Veeresh Kumar and Prashant, with the former arrested in the Krupa Healthcare case and Prashant remaining absconding.

On Tuesday, Karnataka government had shared the inventory of suspected spurious and counterfeit medicines with the Union government and other states. Hospitals, nursing homes and other clinical establishments were directed not to administer medicines identified in the seizures.

Khader said the government acted immediately after the first seizure and did not wait to constitute the SIT. He said the preliminary investigation indicated that cheaper formulations had been sourced from Telangana and Himachal Pradesh, brought to Bidadi, transferred into fresh vials and relabelled as premium imported medicines. "The investigation is underway, and I will place the complete findings before the public once it concludes," Khader said.

The investigation had since moved from the Bidadi facility to a Bengaluru pharmacy and into the supply channels serving hospitals and clinics. The state health minister said he has written to the union health minister seeking the deputation of a central drug surveillance officer to assist in the investigation.

"Since the value of the seized drugs exceeds ₹5 crore, the Centre may also order a CBI probe," he added.

RETAIL INFLATION
HIGHEST IN 12 YRS
CURRENTLY: JOSHI

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HUBBALLI: Union minister Pralad Joshi on Tuesday said retail inflation, which rose to 4.8%, was the highest in the 12 years of the PM Narendra Modi-led government, attributing it to El Nino and other factors, and asserted that efforts were being made to bring it under control.

According to government data released on Monday, retail inflation increased to 4.82 per cent in August, largely driven by higher food prices.

Speaking to reporters here, the Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution Minister said, "I can only say that I am very sensitive about this because our department itself monitors food inflation. We are very sensitive about this issue."

He added that attempts to politicise the issue can't work because the current retail inflation of 4.8 per cent is the highest in the 12 years of the Modi government.

"Until five or six months ago, before the war in West Asia began, our retail inflation was around one per cent or 1.5 per cent," he said.

The minister claimed that today, retail inflation has reached 4.8 per cent because of El Nino and other factors, including natural calamities.

Recalling the inflation during the UPA's tenure, the minister claimed that for over eight years, under the guidance of Sonia and Rahul Gandhi, inflation was almost 10% or more than 10%, and never went below two digits.

Plea in HC against govt's order on Vande Mataram

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BENGALURU: A public interest litigation challenging the state government's decision to limit *Vande Mataram* at most official events, barring those with the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister or Governor present, has been filed with the state high court. The petition has not yet been listed for hearing.

The petitioner, advocate Girish Bharadwaj, argued that the state exceeded its authority by prescribing a shortened version of the national song.

The petition names the Union ministry of home affairs, the state chief secretary and the department of personnel and administrative reforms as respondents.

The petition argued that rules governing national symbols must operate within the constitutional framework and that the state is bound by applicable directions issued by the Centre.

It said that limiting the song at state government functions affected citizens and government employees who attended such programmes.

In January, the Union ministry of home affairs directed that all 6 stanzas of *Vande Mataram* be sung before the national anthem when both are played together.

The directive was issued as the Centre marked the 150th

THE PLEA ARGUES THAT THE STATE EXCEEDED ITS AUTHORITY BY REGULATING A NATIONAL SYMBOL AGAINST CENTRAL GUIDELINES

year of *Vande Mataram*.

The petition says the issue extends beyond an individual grievance because citizens participating in government functions could also be affected. It therefore seeks judicial intervention to ensure that public authorities act within their legal powers.

Bharadwaj had approached the state government on September 14, seeking withdrawal of the order and asking that the officially prescribed complete version of *Vande Mataram* be sung at government programmes. The petition says no response was received, leading him to approach the High Court.

The plea also raised concerns about government employees who may believe that a directive issued by their employer is unlawful.

It argued that employees cannot reasonably be expected to begin legal proceedings against their own government to challenge such an order.

Umar Khalid is a nationalist: State Cong chief

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BENGALURU: State Congress president BK Hariprasad on Tuesday referred to jailed student activist Umar Khalid as a nationalist.

He hit out at the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), which has opposed the screening of a documentary film on Khalid at the National Law School of India University (NLSIU).

"Umar Khalid is a nationalist. The ABVP has no right to speak about Khalid because the ABVP adores Nathuram Godse, who was an anti-national and a terrorist - the first terrorist of the country," Hariprasad told reporters.

On the issue of implementing the Uniform Civil Code in the BJP-ruled states, Hariprasad sought to know whether the saffron party has implemented it in Goa and North East.



BK Hariprasad and Umar Khalid



"What is the point of bringing in UCC? Have they (BJP) brought it in Goa? Have they implemented it there," he asked. The North East is entirely different in terms of religion, Hariprasad said.

"There is no uniformity between the South and the North. So, they cannot try to force anything on the people of this country," he said.

On the reports that he was not invited for the 100 days' event to celebrate the Congress government under Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, Hariprasad

said the CM has already clarified. Reacting to the comments, ABVP said it had "exposed the intellectual bankruptcy of the Congress leader."

Hitting out at Hariprasad, the ABVP, in a statement, said, "How can the Congress party label an individual who openly supported and commemorated a convicted terrorist named Afzal Guru, the mastermind behind the violent attack on the Indian Parliament of 2001 that shed the blood of our brave security personnel - as a nation-

alist."

"If Khalid is a nationalist in Hariprasad's eyes, does the Congress party endorse those who organised events honouring and glorifying Afzal Guru," it added.

"Does Congress support the violent anti-India slogans raised in JNU and the deliberate incitement that led to bloodshed during the 2020 Delhi riots? Giving a patriot certificate to figures facing serious UAPA terror charges reveals Congress's complete compromise on national security," ABVP's Bengaluru city president Abhinandan Mirji told reporters.

Khalid, arrested in September 2020, was booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for being one of the "masterminds" of the February 2020 riots that had left 53 people dead and more than 700 injured in Delhi.

He has since remained jailed without a formal trial having commenced.

Tribute to 'maker of modern Mysore'



Chief minister DK Shivakumar pays floral tribute to Bharat Ratna Sir M Visvesvaraya on his birth anniversary in Bengaluru on Tuesday. September 15 is recognised as 'Engineers Day' in India in honour of Visvesvaraya, who is hailed as the 'maker of modern Mysore. Speaking to reporters at the tribute ceremony, Shivakumar announced that the state government would celebrate Engineers' Day officially from next year.

PTI



3 killed in KSRTC bus-bike collision in Belagavi: Cops

BELAGAVI: Three men were killed when their motorcycle was hit by a government bus in Belagavi district, police said on Tuesday. The incident occurred on the outskirts of Savadatti town of Belagavi district on Monday night. Officers said the men were returning home when the accident occurred. The corporation bus was travelling from Savadatti towards Dharwad, while the motorcycle was heading towards Savadatti.

An investigation into the matter was underway, said police.

3 of family killed after tanker rams bike in Mandya

MANDYA: Three members of a family, including a nine-year-old girl, were killed after a milk tanker ramed their motorcycle from behind in Mandya district on early Tuesday, police said. The accident took place between 5.30am and 6 am in Maddur taluk while the family was returning home to Kanakpura taluk after attending Gauri Ganesha celebrations, they said.

The family was identified as Muthu, his wife Kavya, and their two daughters, one of whom was 9-year-old Kirthana, who was among the deceased.

CM urges MLAs not to politicise rainfall deficit

BENGALURU: Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday urged political parties not to politicise the issue of rainfall deficit by holding political protests or spreading panic among the rural populace. Reassuring farmers, the chief minister said that the state government was committed to supporting them through the crisis. He added that a cabinet meeting was held in Mangaluru to address the growing challenges facing agriculture. "Rainfall is decreasing drastically. I am requesting the MLAs not to panic. There is no need for political protests," he said.



Locals and relatives mourn the deaths near the site where the incident took place in Belagavi on Tuesday.

PTI

4 of family killed after fridge blast sparks fire at house in Belagavi

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BELAGAVI: Four members of a family of daily wage labourers were killed after a refrigerator blast spurred a massive fire that tore through their home in Belagavi city early on Tuesday, said officials.

Those killed were identified as 45-year-old Sharada Gajanan Damone, 50-year-old Bharati Rajaram Damone, 28-year-old Priya Gajanan Damone, 28, and 25-year-old Ganga Gajanan Damone.

The incident took place at Chavat Galli, said police. Belagavi police commissioner Prakash Nikam said a short circuit may have caused the refrigerator to explode. He said the electrical supply department was working to ascertain the cause.

Two members of the family were seriously injured. 65-year-old Gajanan Rajaram Damone suffered burns on 90% of his body, said doctors, while 21-year-

old Roshan Gajanan Damone suffered burns on 20% of his body. Both were admitted to the Belagavi Institute of Medical Sciences (BIMS).

A preliminary probe said the fire's rapid spread gave the family little time to escape. Police and emergency personnel reached the house after receiving information and began rescue operations.

Officers from Market police station inspected the house and examined its electrical connections. Statements from neighbours and witnesses were also recorded. The bodies were sent for postmortem examination.

Belagavi North Congress MLA Asif Saith reached the spot around 3.30 am. District in-charge minister Satish Jarkiholi and Belagavi deputy commissioner Roshan Mohammed visited the site later in the morning. Jarkiholi and Saith said they would ask the government to provide appropriate compensation to the affected family.

{ CM PRESIDES OVER 'WORLD DEMOCRACY DAY' EVENT }

'Authoritarianism born when people fear govt'

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday said democracy turns into authoritarianism when people fear the government and stressed the need to protect democratic values by ensuring equal dignity and opportunity for all.

Addressing an event to mark World Democracy Day, Shivakumar said democracy was not confined to elections but encompassed people's rights, dignity and public participation.

"If people are afraid of the government, it becomes authoritarianism. When the government respects its people, it becomes democracy," he said.

In addition to the five existing guarantee schemes, such as free bus travel for women, the government was also considering a



CM DK Shivakumar, deputy CM G Parameshwara and others pay tribute to Dr BR Ambedkar and Babu Jagjivan Ram at the event in Vidhana Soudha Banquet Hall on Tuesday.

PTI

sixth, the "land guarantee," Shivakumar said.

He said India had a long democratic tradition, recalling the 12th-century Anubhava Mantapa and its emphasis on equality and participation. He said he had visited the historic institution at Basavakalyan within three days of becoming chief

minister.

The CM also stressed the need to give young people opportunities to enter public life at all levels.

Recalling his own experiences in school and college elections, Shivakumar said he had faced attempts to block his political participation, but con-

Hot spell in city continues despite rain forecast

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BENGALURU: Bengaluru continued to record above normal temperatures on Tuesday despite intermittent rain, with the city observatory recording a maximum of 32.1°C, 3.5°C above normal.

The reading came two days after the city recorded 32.6°C on September 13, while the Kempegowda International Airport observatory recorded 33.9°C on the same day, the highest September temperature in Bengaluru's historical record.

The latest figures showed that rain has not brought about a sustained fall in daytime temperatures inside the city.

The India Meteorological

Department's Bengaluru forecast continued to indicate the possibility of rain or thunder-showers towards the evening or night, while maximum temperatures are expected to remain around 32°C through the week.

The corresponding September maximums recorded at the city observatory were 29.9°C in 2025, 31.6°C in 2024, 30.8°C in 2023, 31°C in 2022, 31.3°C in 2021 and 30.6°C in 2020.

The airport reading, however, marked a different benchmark. At 33.9°C, it was 0.6°C above the previous September record of 33.3°C recorded on September 16, 1951.

The contrast between rain and temperature has persisted through the month.

Showers have brought tem-

THE IMD HAS NOT CLASSIFIED THE PREVAILING CONDITIONS AS A HEAT WAVE, AS THE CRITERIA HAS NOT BEEN MET, SAID A SENIOR OFFICIAL

porary relief in parts of the city, but daytime temperatures have continued to return to the low 30s when cloud cover decreases.

N Puviarasan, director in charge of the IMD in Bengaluru, said the rise in temperatures was linked to poor monsoon conditions, limited cloud cover and a change in surface winds.

"The rise in temperature is because of poor monsoon, no cloud cover and north-westerly winds, instead of the seasonal south-westerly, prevailing at surface level," Puviarasan said.

He said the winds were dry and carried little moisture, contributing to higher temperatures across south and interior Karnataka.

"The surface wind is dry and carries no moisture, leading to high temperatures, particularly in south and interiors of Karnataka," he said.

The IMD has not classified the conditions as a heat wave. Puviarasan said that although temperatures may feel similar to heat wave conditions across parts of Karnataka, the criteria required for an official declara-

tion had not been met.

The latest IMD data also show differences between Bengaluru's three major observation stations. For September 14, the Bengaluru International Airport recorded 34.2°C, while the city observatory recorded 33.2°C and HAL recorded 32.3°C.

On September 15, the city observatory recorded 32.1°C, with 0.0 mm of measurable rainfall during the preceding 24 hours, while the airport recorded 33.7°C with 0.6 mm of rain. HAL recorded 31°C after receiving 27.6 mm of rain.

For the city, the immediate forecast points to more of the same: maximum temperatures around 32°C, with rain or thunder-showers possible towards the evening or night.

3 DMK leaders booked over remarks on TN CM

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu police have registered cases against Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) leaders, including party deputy general secretary and former Union minister A Raja and former state minister PK Sekar Babu, over alleged derogatory remarks made by them against Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay and his cabinet colleague CTR Nirmal Kumar, officials familiar with the matter said on Tuesday.

A similar case against DMK MLA Vasantham Karthikeyan over his comments against the chief minister was also filed by the Kallakurichi police.

The DMK had organised a state-wide protest on September 12 during which A Raja, P K Sekar Babu and Vasantham Karthikeyan in Kallakurichi allegedly made 'derogatory' remarks against Vijay and Kumar.

The comments made by Raja and Sekar Babu was widely circulated on the social media and triggered spark reactions from various political parties including DMK MP Kanimozhi Karun-



DMK leaders A Raja and P K Sekar Babu



anidhi.

According to the police, cases were filed against A Raja under sections including defamatory remarks against an individual with the intention to disturb peace, inciting violence between groups, use of obscene language and acts causing disruption to public order under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

"We have registered a case. We cannot tell any more than this," a senior police officer told HT, requesting anonymity.

On cases filed against former HR and CE minister P K Sekar Babu, a senior officer of North Chennai police said first infor-

mation reports (FIRs) have been registered under relevant sections of BNS, including 296 (reciting an obscene song or words in or near a public place), 352 (intentional insult to provoke breach of peace), 196 (1) (promoting enmity), 353 (1) (spreading false information in any medium including social media), 352 (2) (intentional speech that will break public peace) and 351 (2) (whoever threatens another person with injury to their body, reputation or property).

Meanwhile, when reporters asked about the filing of cases against DMK, A Raja said, "Is

this a question? if a lawsuit is filed, we just have to face it."

DMK spokesperson TKS Elangovan said, "As an opposition party we have the right to criticise, attack the ruling party for their mistakes. But this government is only working against the DMK people when our Leader of Opposition (Udhayanidhi Stalin) have asked that so many crimes have happened, so many custodial deaths have happened, so many attacks on women were made they (TVK government) did not have any answer."

Elangovan further said, "they will continue to attack the DMK. So, whatever LoP spoke in the assembly, they have no answer, and they have not arrested anybody or filed a case against anybody to ensure that criminals are punished. But they will file case against Raja, and they have also filed cases against LoP and they will do all those things."

Charging the ruling Tamila Vettri Kazhagam that their intention was to attack the DMK, Elangovan alleged, "during the entire session of the assembly, these ministers did not defend their deeds but they have only attacked the DMK."

ANDHRA RAISES UPPER AGE LIMIT FOR GOVT JOB HIRING TO 44 YRS

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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh government issued orders enhancing the upper age limit for direct recruitment to various government posts by two more years, providing greater opportunities to unemployed youth who have been affected by limited recruitment over the past several years, officials familiar with the matter said on Tuesday.

Simultaneously, the Andhra Pradesh Public Service Commission (APPSC) issued separate notifications to fill a total of 892 vacancies across various departments. The recruitment includes 163 Group-I category posts.

The APPSC made the detailed notifications, including eligibility criteria, recruitment examination procedures and other relevant information, available on its official website.

According to a state order by chief secretary G Sai Prasad, the upper age limit for direct recruitment to posts in all non-uniform services through APPSC and other recruiting agencies has been raised from 34 to 44 years. The relaxation will remain in force for recruitments notified up to September 30, 2027.

The government had earlier enhanced the upper age limit from 34 to 42 years and extended the concession periodically since 2016. The latest order replaces the earlier limit of 42 years with 44 years and extends its validity by another year.

7 BRS workers held over 'purification' ritual: Cops

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HYDERABAD: Telangana police on Tuesday announced arrest of seven Bharata Rashtra Samithi workers in connection with the alleged "purification" of the road and surroundings near the farmhouse of BRS president and former chief minister K Chandrasekhar Rao at Erravelli in Siddipet district, following a protest by Dalit workers of the Congress party on September 8.

Markook sub-inspector MA Yusuf said the arrests were made on Monday in connection with the alleged purification rituals. The accused BRS workers were identified as Praveen Appala, Raju Arikela, Raju Kodari, Himavanth alias Bhanu Macha, Mallesham Kammanthani, Ilaiah Kammanthani and Amarendar Reddaboyina.

"The accused were produced before a court in Gajwel late on Tuesday and were remanded to two-week judicial custody. They were later shifted to Siddipet jail," the police official said.

According to police, a total of 21 people were identified as accused in the three cases registered over the incident. Of them, seven have so far been arrested, while the remaining 14 are absconding.

On September 8, several Dalit activists belonging to the Congress organised a "Chavu Dappu" (drum-beating) demonstrations at KCR's farmhouse at Erravelli village in protest

A TOTAL OF 21 PEOPLE WERE IDENTIFIED AS ACCUSED IN THE THREE CASES REGISTERED OVER THE INCIDENT. OF THEM, SEVEN HAVE BEEN ARRESTED, WHILE 14 REMAIN ABSCONDING

against alleged abusive comments made by BRS MLC Tata Madhu against Telangana assembly speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar, who belongs to the Scheduled Caste community.

Hours after the protest, BRS leaders and workers allegedly carried out a symbolic "purification" by sprinkling or pouring turmeric water and milk on stretches of road through which the protesters had passed.

In his complaint, a Dalit activist Srikanth lodged a complaint with the police alleging that the BRS workers conducted "purification" in the area by sprinkling turmeric water on the road near the Hanuman temple at Varadarajapur village near Erravelli, suggesting that the presence of Dalits had rendered the area impure.

Police registered three separate FIRs on September 10 in connection with similar incidents. One case relates to the

alleged purification at Varadarajapur, while the other two concern similar acts near the Brahman Gari temple in Erravelli and on the road between Varadarajapur and the Erravelli farmhouse.

The cases were registered under Sections 196 and 352 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Sections 3(1)(r) and 3(1)(u) of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, and Section 7 of the Protection of Civil Rights Act.

The alleged purification ritual triggered sharp criticism and comparisons with a similar 'shuddhikaran' ritual at Haldwani's Ramlila Maidan in Uttarakhand following a rally addressed by AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge. Kharge had publicly expressed his anguish over the incident, saying it reminded him of the continuing pain of untouchability.

The Telangana government subsequently constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT), headed by senior IPS officer Vijay Kumar, to conduct a comprehensive investigation into the incident and initiate action against those responsible.

The SIT and local police continued searches for the accused for nearly six days. According to police, the accused from Varadarajapur had fled to Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh and were staying there. With the assistance of the local police in Vijayawada, the Telangana police arrested seven of them on Monday.

VIJAYAWADA COPS SEIZE BAG WITH EXPLOSIVES AT BUS STATION

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HYDERABAD: Police in Andhra Pradesh's Vijayawada on Tuesday confiscated a bag containing explosive material from a passenger who complained of a baggage mix-up at the busy Pandit Nehru Bus Station.

Vijayawada assistant commissioner of police (south zone) K Manasa said the bag contained 46 gelatin sticks and 50 detonators. "We have launched an investigation to trace the owner of the bag and the purpose for which he was taking the explosive material," she said.

The incident was reported at 1 am on Tuesday, when a passenger, Asif Ali of Uttar Pradesh, who was coming from Narasaraopet in Palnadu district to Vijayawada, noticed that his bag was mixed up with another bag.

"When he realised that he had picked up a wrong bag on his arrival in Vijayawada after his bag was missing, he opened the bag and found the explosives inside. He immediately alerted police at the bus stand outpost belonging to Krishnalanka police station," the ACP said.

Police are examining passenger records and CCTV footage from the bus station to identify the owner of the bag. "We have formed special teams to trace its owner. A sniffer dog and a bomb detection squad were pressed into service," Manasa said.

Krishnalanka police have registered a case under the Explosives Act and provisions of BNS and launched an investigation.

Krishnalanka police inspector J Murali Krishna said prima facie, it appears the detonators and gelatin sticks were meant for quarry operations. "We shall investigate why the owner placed the bag in the bus, whether he had any licence for quarrying and procurement of explosive materials," he said.

Vijayawada deputy commissioner of police Krishna Kanth Patil said the case was being probed from all angles.

Various party candidates file papers for TN bypolls, campaigns intensify

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Candidates representing the opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), and other political parties filed their nominations on Tuesday, intensifying the campaign for next month's bypoll in Tamil Nadu.

The Left parties - Communist Party of India (Marxist) announced its candidate by nominating party veteran B Suganthi as the candidate for the Madurantakam (SC) segment while the CPI fielded P Lakshmanan as the nominee for the Dharapuram (SC) constituencies, making it as a multi-corner contest.

The bypoll has been necessitated following the resignation of K Maragatham Kumaravel and P Sathyabama who successfully contested under All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) tickets, tendered

resignations as legislators before joining the TVK. The ruling party have re-nominated them as its candidates for the by-poll.

The opposition DMK has fielded the party's legal wing joint secretary I Paranthaman as its candidate for the Madurantakam (SC) constituency while S Suganya, an advocate has been given a ticket to contest from the Dharapuram (SC) assembly segment.

On Tuesday, both the DMK candidates flanked by party leaders, filed their nomination papers with returning officers.

The AIADMK has nominated former legislator Kanitha Sampath (Madurantakam SC) and the Tiruppur suburban East women's wing joint secretary K Bhanumathi (Dharapuram) as the candidates.

The candidates of AIADMK and the Left parties (who were announced on Tuesday) are expected to file their nomination on Wednesday.

Party workers have already commenced the campaign activities and have been holding public meetings over the last few days.

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam is seeking to increase its victory count from the earlier 108 seats to 110 seats thereby strengthening its foothold in the Secretariat, while the AIADMK is attempting to retain the constituencies which it had won in the April 23 Assembly election. The two seats have been considered as a traditional strongholds for the AIADMK.

The DMK is aiming to boost its position in the Assembly with the nomination of the two candidates.

The filing of nominations commenced on September 9 and September 16th (Wednesday) is the last day. The bypoll is scheduled to be held on October 6 while counting of votes would be taken up on October 9, the Election Commission said.

Sitharaman at convocation ceremony



Union finance and corporate affairs minister Nirmala Sitharaman at a convocation ceremony of Dr MGR Educational & Research Institute in Chennai on Tuesday. "You should ask yourselves what you can do for the country, rather than asking what the country has done for you; you must realise the value of your own contributions to the nation," she told the youth.

T'gana seeks support of Aga Khan Foundation for Musi's rejuvenation

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Tuesday sought support of Aga Khan Foundation in the state government's ambitious Musi Rejuvenation Project, particularly for the restoration and conservation of heritage structures along the Musi River corridor.

During a meeting with Prince Rahim Aga Khan V, hereditary trustee of Aga Khan Foundation, at Taj Falaknuma Palace in Hyderabad on Tuesday, the CM explained about his government's efforts to rejuvenate the Musi River, on the banks of which Hyderabad city was built.

Revanth Reddy said the river, formed at the confluence of the Esi and Musi rivers, had suffered



A Revanth Reddy with Prince Rahim Aga Khan V at Taj Falaknuma Palace in Hyderabad on Tuesday.

from encroachments and pollution over the years. "The government has prepared plans to revive the Musi and use the river corridor as a catalyst for developing Hyderabad's night-time economy," he said.

As part of the initiative, Reddy sought the Foundation's assistance in restoring the City College and Osmania General Hospital buildings, both located along the Musi River corridor.

The CM said a new building for Osmania General Hospital was being constructed at Goshamahall. He requested Prince Rahim Aga Khan V to consider the existing Osmania Hospital building as a heritage asset and undertake its conservation and development through the Aga Khan Foundation.

Revanth Reddy also recalled the foundation's previous contribution to heritage conservation in Hyderabad and Telangana. He recalled that the foundation had played a key role in the restoration of heritage properties, including the Qutb Shahi Tombs.

TENDERS ISSUED FOR COMPLETED WORK, SAYS NGO; TN GOVT CLARIFIES

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: A Chennai-based NGO Arappor Iyakkam alleged on Tuesday that two beautification works worth ₹45 lakh by Tambaram Corporation were completed and inaugurated before tenders were floated for bidding process.

The NGO alleged the tenders were published on August 6 but the works were inaugurated on July 29. Responding to the findings, the state government said administrative sanction was obtained on July 14 after placing a proposal before the council to execute two city beautification works under the Tambaram Corporation limit either through general funds or CSR.

On July 23, the Corporation Commissioner granted permission to issue tender notices. On July 24, a private firm offered to execute the works. The government said a procedural flaw was identified wherein tender notice was issued later on August 6. No work order was issued and no costs incurred. Concerned zonal assistant executive engineer was suspended.

Proposed Keralam law aims to upskill elderly care-giving sector: CMO

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A proposed law for the care and protection of elderly persons in Keralam will aim to professionalise the caregiving sector and build a framework for geriatric care, the chief minister's office said on Tuesday.

Chief minister VD Satheesan, chairing a meeting to review the draft Keralam State Elderly Persons (Care and Protection) Bill, 2026 in Thiruvananthapuram, directed officials to expedite the procedures associated with drafting the legislation.

The bill's stated aim is to establish a comprehensive elderly-friendly system, taking into account the state's changing demographic structure.

The legislation, once passed, would fix quality standards and responsibilities of assisted living facilities, home care agencies and government homes housing destitute elderly persons, the CM's office said.

"One of the main objectives is developing the caregiving

sector into a professional system. For this, a framework for geriatric care certification will be formed. Care givers would be given training and certification. Their backgrounds would be checked and a state-wide registry will be developed. This will help create jobs for skilled caregivers," the office further said.

The government, the CM's office said, was committed to building a 'silver economy' that would tie the rising needs of elderly persons with new economic and employment opportunities.

State and district-level mechanisms would be put in place for the effective implementation of the bill's goals, it said.

Figures from the Registrar General of India have stated that the population of those aged 60 and above in Keralam is expected to rise to one-fourth of the state's population in less than a decade.

The figure of those aged 60 and above in the state in 2026 is 18.7%, compared to the national average of 11.4%.

CPI(M) meet concludes, no major leadership changes

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The CPI(M) extended state committee meeting in Kozhikode concluded on Tuesday by effecting a nominal organisational rejig and steering clear of replacing its top leadership.

The meeting, attended by over 300 of the top leaders of the state unit and invitees from the state leadership, was envisaged to find new ways to strengthen the organisation, fix lapses and infuse energy into its ranks, four months after suffering a drubbing in the Assembly polls. The CPI(M) lost power in the state after a decade and saw its numbers in the Assembly dwindle from 62 to 26.

CPI(M) state secretary MV Govindan announced the organisational changes approved at the meeting in Kozhikode. The state secretariat, highest body of the party at the state level, saw the induction of three prominent leaders - P Jayarajan from Kannur, MB Rajesh from Palakkad and V Sivankutty from Thiruvananthapuram districts.

While Jayarajan is considered a party strongman in Kannur with wide clout among the cadre, Rajesh and Sivankutty served as local self-government and general education ministers respectively in the second Pinarayi Vijayan cabinet. Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas will also work in close conjunction with the state



CPI(M) leaders M A Baby and Pinarayi Vijayan at the state committee meeting in Kozhikode on Tuesday. HT PHOTO

secretariat.

At the same time, LDF convenor TP Ramakrishnan and former finance minister TM Thomas Isaac found themselves out of the secretariat. Notably, in the days leading to the conference, Isaac had publicly spoken about the need for the party leadership to listen to the grievances of the cadre and the public, instead of vice versa.

The state committee of the party also saw notable inductions, especially of youth and women. Nine people were selected as permanent invitees - Adarsh M Sajeev, national president of SFI, Jaik C Thomas, national DYFI leader, PS Sanjeev, state SFI secretary, M Sivasubramanian, state SFI president, N Sukanya, MLA OS Ambika, Subaida Ishaque, DYFI state secretary M Vijin and writer Prabha Varma.

At the same time, Govindan

did not disclose the specific organisational lapses discovered during internal reviews or the ways in which the party would rectify them in the months ahead. It is learnt that there was intense debate on the party's shortcomings at the meeting in Kozhikode, especially over the stunning defeats in its strongholds of Payyanur and Taliparamba. In effect, the CPI(M) shied away from making any major changes in the top echelons of the leadership at the state level.

The party, at the Kozhikode conference, adopted three resolutions. In one resolution, it vowed to legally and politically fight against the "political witch-hunt" being conducted by the BJP-led Union government through central agencies like the Enforcement Directorate against Pinarayi Vijayan and MLA PA Mohammed Riyas. The reference is to the ED probing allegations of money laundering in the CMRL - Exalogic case involving the defunct firm of Veena T, daughter of Vijayan.

In the second resolution, the CPI(M) exhorted its cadres to unite against the "anti-people" policies of the UDF government. It accused the UDF of joining hands with communal forces and destroying the state's secular heritage. In the third resolution, it called for public protests against the "corporate-Hindutva" policies of the Union government and soaring unemployment.

PARTIES SPAR IN TAMIL NADU OVER VIJAY'S VISIT TO UNITED KINGDOM

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu has signed memorandum of understandings with various companies committing ₹15,300 crore investments in the State, the government said on Tuesday. The MoUs are expected to generate over 10,000 new jobs in the state.

Several agreements were executed between the state government and global corporates in the presence of chief minister C Joseph Vijay to establish and expand manufacturing plants, setting up of Global Capability Centres, research and development facilities in Tamil Nadu.

Meanwhile, the BJP termed the visit of the CM as an 'over-sold publicity exercise'.

BJP Tamil Nadu chief spokesperson Narayanan said, the CM's team flew to London to sign with companies that already have presence in Tamil Nadu and then called it as a historic investment.

"The biggest deal is an Indian firm Motherson from Noida, Wilson Power already signed MoU in 2025 and opened a plant this year. Sigma arrived earlier this year while Ernst and Young was already here. That is not new investment. That is old business with a foreign backdrop," Thirupathi said in a statement.

Meanwhile, the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) took a dig at the CM's trip to the London and signing of MoUs, stating that Motherson established in India in 1986 having headquarters in Noida, the chief minister all the way travels to the United Kingdom at tax payers money to attract investment. "On the path laid by (DMK Chief) M K Stalin, the tourist trip embarked by C Joseph Vijay continues," he wrote in a social media post.

HEALTH OF SITTING TVK MLA 'STABLE': CHENNAI HOSPITAL

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CHENNAI: The health condition of veteran politician and sitting legislator VS Babu remains 'stable' and he is being closely monitored by a multidisciplinary team of experts, the hospital treating him said on Tuesday.

A seasoned politician, Babu shot to fame after defeating the former chief minister M K Stalin at the Kolathur constituency in the April 23 Assembly polls.

He was admitted to a city-based healthcare provider MGM Healthcare on September 9 for 'respiratory ailment'. A bulletin from MGM Healthcare said on Tuesday, "His condition is being closely monitored by the multidisciplinary team of experts. His clinical parameters are completely optimal and his overall condition remains stable."

'99 Staines murder case: Odisha rejects Dara Singh's release plea

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BHUBANESWAR: Odisha's State Sentence Review Board has rejected a plea for premature release by Dara Singh, who is serving life imprisonment for the 1999 murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor sons, ending months of uncertainty over his remission plea.

The board's decision comes ahead of the next hearing in Supreme Court on September 17, and after multiple prompts from the apex court.

The board, which considered the case at its special meeting on August 31 said Singh's release could have "societal ramifications" and potentially lead to communal disturbances in the area. District authorities in Keonjhar, where Singh is lodged in a jail, had in March 2025 conditionally recommended that he could be allowed premature release, but made this contingent on imposing conditions to ensure social harmony. In its latest report, the district administration reported that

a crowd of about 200 to 250 people associated with the Dara Sena assembled outside the Keonjhar District Jail on August 15 and raised provocative slogans.

HT has reviewed a copy of the minutes of the board meeting.

The board noted that the latest report from the Keonjhar administration did not contain a specific recommendation and was inconclusive.

Singh, 67, has spent more than 26 years and six months in prison and became eligible for consideration for premature release under Odisha's 2022 remission guidelines. He approached the Supreme Court in 2024 seeking directions to the Odisha government to consider his premature release under those guidelines.

The board had earlier rejected his plea of premature release in November 2016, June 2019, December 2020, January 2022 and February 2023 citing various grounds, including concerns over communal harmony.

The latest decision came after the top court last week directed the state government to take a clear position on Singh's plea.



Singh was convicted for the killing of Graham Staines and his two sons.

"You want to reject it, you do it. You take a decision. We will deal with it. You can't keep it lingering like this," the SC bench of justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi said while warning that state officials could be summoned if the Sentence Review Board continued to delay its decision. The court, on August 19, directed the board to take a decision by September 2 and inform it of the outcome.

Singh was convicted for the killing of Staines and his sons, Philip, 10, and Timothy, 6, who were burnt alive while sleeping in a sta-

tion wagon at Manoharpur in Odisha's Kendujhar district on January 22, 1999. A CBI court sentenced Singh to death in 2003 and convicted him under several provisions of IPC including murder, criminal conspiracy and rioting.

Following an appeal, the Orissa High Court in 2005 acquitted 11 other accused and commuted Singh's death sentence to life imprisonment. His appeal against the conviction was subsequently dismissed by the Supreme Court.

Singh was also convicted in two other murder cases in Mayurbhanj district — the killing of Catholic priest Father Arul Doss at Jambani Church and the murder of garment shop owner SK Rahman. He received life sentences in both cases in 2007. His appeals were later dismissed by the Orissa High Court.

One of his co-accused, Mahendra Hembram, was released prematurely from Kendujhar district jail in April 2025.

Singh first sought premature release through the state review process several years ago, but successive boards rejected or deferred his plea. After a 2023

direction from the Orissa High Court, the Sentence Review Board held a special meeting on February 20 that year and again rejected his request.

His case was placed before the board in November 2024, when it sought a fresh opinion from the district authorities. Kendujhar officials subsequently recommended his release in March 2025, subject to conditions.

The board nevertheless deferred the matter in May 2025, citing his convictions in three murder cases and seeking further reports.

It again deferred the case in September 2025, seeking a fresh opinion from authorities in Auraiya district of Uttar Pradesh, where Singh originally lived. The Auraiya authorities subsequently supported his premature release in February 2026.

In July 2024, the Supreme Court said his premature release should have been considered by the competent state committee.

The matter was subsequently adjourned several times as the state sought time for the review process.

2 women killed as fresh violence rocks Manipur

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IMPHAL: Two women, suspected to be from the Kuki community, were gunned down allegedly by unidentified armed miscreants in a village in Manipur's Tamenglong district, police said on Tuesday, two days after four civilians were shot dead in the same district amid the ongoing ethnic violence in the state.

According to police, the incident occurred at around 3.30pm in Muktakhal village.

"We recovered the bodies and sent them to Silchar Medical College and Hospital, Assam, in the evening," said a Kaimai police official, adding that those responsible for the crime are yet to be identified and probe is underway to nab the miscreants.

The Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), a Kuki body, identified the deceased as 60-year-old Phalnei-chong Sithlou, alias Chonga Sithhouand, and Kimjalhing alias Kimnei Singson.

They were allegedly attacked and killed by armed cadres belonging to National Socialist Council of Nagaland-Isak-Mui-vah (NSCN-IM) and Zeliangrong Union Front faction associated with Kamson faction (ZUF-K)

THE INCIDENT COMES TWO DAYS AFTER FOUR CIVILIANS WERE GUNNED DOWN IN TAMENGLONG DISTRICT

while practicing agricultural activities, the Kuki body said.

"Over the past three days, including today, six innocent Kuki villagers have reportedly been killed in cold blood. Today, two women, residents of Muktokhol (Leisangphai) village, who had gone to their jhum fields, were reportedly waylaid and shot dead in their own fields by NSCN-IM and its cohorts," KIM said in a statement. KIM said that targeting innocent civilians and failure of authorities to protect the civilians are pushing the situation towards extreme state.

The Kuki body urged the central government and state government to act immediately and decisively to stop further attack, protect civilians and bring responsible for the killing to justice.

Meanwhile, Kuki Zo Council (KZC) another Kuki-Zo body has announced a resolution and noti-

fied to all Civil society organisations across Kuki-Zo districts that "No Kuki-Zo person killed by Naga armed groups in Manipur shall be buried until further notice. The mortal remains of every such victim shall instead be preserved in the nearest available cold-storage facility until further directions are issued by the Kuki-Zo Council," KZC said in a statement.

On Sunday, four people, including a couple, were killed and a six-year-old sustained a bullet injury in two separate attacks by armed miscreants in Tamenglong.

Naga and Kuki-Zo tensions escalated after the May 13 twin ambushes. On the same day, Kuki-Zo and Naga groups captured 48 people. On May 15, 14 captives each from the two communities were released. The remaining 14 Kuki-Zo hostages were freed unharmed on June 9. Mutilated bodies of the six Nagas were found the next day.

The ethnic violence in the state began in 2023 between the Meitei and Kuki communities. The ethnic violence in Manipur first began in 2023 between the Meitei and Kuki communities before involving almost every community. The state's Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities have shut each other out of the areas they dominate.

BJP fields mother of Suvendu's slain aide for Nandigram bypoll

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KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suvendu Adhikari on Tuesday said the upcoming bypolls to two assembly seats in the state were a "test" for minority voters to prove their allegiance to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government, even as the ruling party fielded Hasirani Rath, mother of Adhikari's slain aide, from Nandigram in the October 6 by-election.

Rath's son Chadrannath Rath, Adhikari's former personal assistant, was shot dead in North 24 Parganas district on May 6, two days after the BJP swept the assembly polls in the state.

Adhikari appealed to the minority community to vote for the BJP. "The bypoll in Nandigram and Rejinagar on October 6 will be your test of whether you want to be with the government and the chief minister and work hand-in-hand. I leave it to you whether you want to pass or fail in the test," the CM said. The BJP has also fielded Sakharav Sarkar from Rejinagar in the Muslim-majority Murshidabad district.

The bypolls were necessitated by Adhikari, who won from Bhabanipur and Nandigram in the 2026 assembly polls, giving up Nandigram, and AJUP leader Humayun Kabir, who also won from Naoda, vacating the Rejinagar seat. Both constituencies have sizeable minority voters.

Adhikari made the appeal while accompanying Hasirani



CM Suvendu Adhikari with Hasirani Rath, mother of his slain aide.

Rath to the Haldia SDO office to file her nomination.

The CM's remarks, however, sparked a political row, with the Trinamool Congress (TMC) led by Mamata Banerjee and the Congress accusing him of threatening the minority community.

"All this while we knew that elections are a test for the political parties and their candidates. But this is the first time we are hearing it is a test for a section of voters," said TMC spokesperson Krishanu Mitra. "...The BJP has come to know very well that the fight is not so easy."

Congress leader Soumya Aich Roy said: "This is nothing but a veiled threat. Creating a rift among communities forms the baseline of BJP's politics. The chief minister has virtually announced that if the BJP loses the Rejinagar seat, there will be no development works. The BJP is afraid because the party is losing ground..."

Wednesday is the last day to file nominations for the October 6 bypolls. The results will be declared on October 9.

WEST BENGAL COP TRANSFERRED FOR 'ISLAMIC GREETINGS'

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KOLKATA: The West Bengal government on Monday transferred IPS officer Bushra Bano from additional superintendent of police, West Midnapore, to deputy commandant of the 4th battalion of the State Armed Police, a day after a Hindu group complained to the state home secretary over a social media video in which she allegedly used Islamic greetings instead of "Vande Mataram" or "Jai Hind."

"She began with Assalamualaikum, used Inshallah, ended with Jazakallah — and did not use Vande Mataram or Jai Hind. A serving officer representing the Indian state should maintain neutrality and use national expressions in public communication," Hindu Legal Fund wrote on X on Sunday.

In a video clip on social media, the 2021-batch IPS officer could purportedly be seen describing how the Residential Coaching Academy (RCA) at the Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) in Uttar Pradesh helped her during her preparations for the civil service exam and how UPSC aspirants could benefit from the academy.

"...In a video about her journey and how AMU's RCA helped her, she used the same words her community has used for centuries. Suddenly that's 'problematic'. Hindu officers say Namaste. Some say Jai Shri Ram. Sikh officers say Sat Sri Akal. Nobody loses sleep..." the Muslim IT Cell wrote on X.

BJP partners in UP yet to open cards on UCC

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LUCKNOW: The ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners in Uttar Pradesh seem to be treading with caution in declaring their support to the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), especially ahead of the assembly polls in the country's most populous province.

The contentious issue has returned to the state's political discourse after Union home minister Amit Shah, on September 13, asserted that the UCC would be implemented in all NDA-ruled states before 2029.

For the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), UCC is part of its core ideological trioka, besides the Ram Temple and the abrogation of Article 370.

"The UCC has always been part of BJP's core goal and election manifesto like the abrogation of Article 370 in J&K. The party is committed to bring UCC," said Dinesh Pratap Singh, state BJP's chief spokesperson. "Now, after Union home minister's statement, the state government will move in this direction."

SO FAR, NONE OF THE BJP'S ALLIES IN THE STATE HAVE OPPOSED HOME MINISTER AMIT SHAH'S PROMISE TO IMPLEMENT THE UCC IN NDA STATES BEFORE 2029

A section of the BJP believes the UCC might help the party in countering the opposition's poll plank in the caste-sensitive state ahead of the 2027 assembly polls.

"The narrative around UCC will help the party counter the opposition's poll plank on caste to some extent," said a senior BJP leader, requesting anonymity.

BJP's allies in Uttar Pradesh, however, are yet to disclose their official stand, while treading the issue with caution.

"I will not comment on the issue at present. I will get back after consulting the party high command," said Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) national general secretary Anil Dubey. Led by Jayant

Chaudhary, the RLD is part of the NDA at the Centre and in the state, with its core base being Jats and farmers in western UP.

Another alliance partner, Apna Dal (Soneylal), which has a core base of Kurmis and non-Yadav OBCs in eastern Uttar Pradesh, is also yet to formally announce its support to the UCC. Party's state chief RP Gautam refused to comment, saying the party high command will comment on the issue. Party chief Anupriya Patel is a junior minister at the Centre.

Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), led by Om Prakash Rajbhar, has also not made its stand clear on the UCC.

To be sure, none of the BJP's allies in UP have openly opposed Shah's assertion on the UCC.

Meanwhile, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav in a post on X on Tuesday said: "Public understands that the UCC [that] BJP is talking about actually has a different full form: UCC = Underground Communal Conspiracy. First fulfill previous promises, then bring UCC. Transfer ₹15 lakh into accounts, then bring UCC. Provide 2 crore jobs, then bring UCC"

BRING UCC TO PARL, NOT JUST BJP-RULED STATES: OMAR TO GOVT

SRINAGAR: Jammu & Kashmir chief minister Omar Abdullah on Tuesday challenged the Centre to table a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill in Parliament rather than implementing in piecemeal, arguing that a civil code cannot be termed universal if it applies only to states ruled by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Reacting to Union home minister Amit Shah's assertion that UCC will be rolled out across 21 NDA-governed states by 2029, Abdullah highlighted opposition within the ruling coalition itself, referring to reports that JD(U) will not permit its implementation in Bihar. "If you have numbers, bring the Bill to Parliament. Why push it through individual states?" Abdullah said. "Not everyone in the NDA agrees. The JD(U) has made it clear it won't be implemented in Bihar. If their own allies aren't on board, how can they claim it will cover the entire country? They should table it in House and test if they actually have the numbers to pass it." **HTC**

WILL FIRST EXAMINE PROPOSED UCC BILL, SAYS BIHAR DY CM

PATNA: Bihar deputy chief minister and senior JD(U) leader Vijay Kumar Chaudhary on Tuesday said a decision on the implementation of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in the state would be taken only after examining the provisions of the proposed bill and discussions within the JD(U).

The JD(U), an ally of the BJP in the NDA coalition in Bihar, continues to hold reservations over the implementation of the UCC, which has come into currency after Union home minister Amit Shah's recent statement that it would be implemented in all 21 NDA ruled states by 2029. "Let the provisions of the proposed UCC Bill come before us. We will examine it and then we will discuss about it. Secondly, our working national president has already said that after reviewing the provisions, there will be direct talks with the home minister Amit Shah and after that our party will hold a meeting," said Chaudhary, while talking to reporters. **HTC**

NIA bid to join ED's probe into 2022 TN blast sparks turf battle

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NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) last week attempted to insert itself in an Enforcement Directorate (ED) interrogation of key suspects in the 2022 Coimbatore bomb blast by an Islamic State-inspired module, a move which was turned down.

The October 23, 2022 vehicle-borne explosion outside the Arulmigu Kottai Sangameswarar Thirukovil temple in Coimbatore killed only the suicide bomber, Jameesha Mubeen. The NIA, which is investigating the case since then, has arrested over a dozen individuals.

The ED in June filed a money laundering case in the case as it received information on the financing activities of the module involved. It approached a Chennai special court seeking to interrogate four accused persons including key masterminds, Umar Faaruq and Sheikh Hidayatullah. The duo is lodged in Tiruchirappalli central prison. The ED had sought to question two others—Aboo Hanifa and Pavas Rahman, both lodged in Puzhal central jail. ED informed the court that Hidayatullah and Faaruq orchestrated a fake Covid-19 vaccination certificate scam during 2021-22 to generate proceeds of crime for ter-

LAST WEEK, NIA TRIED TO INSERT ITSELF INTO ED'S INTERROGATION OF SUSPECTS IN THE 2022 SUICIDE BOMB ATTACK THAT TOOK PLACE IN COIMBATORE

ror activities, which was facilitated by Pavas Rahman and another accused Sharan Mariappan (out on bail) while Aboo Hanifa routed the proceeds. Hidayatullah was allegedly in been touch with the April 21, 2019 Sri Lanka bombings mastermind Maulvi Zahrnan bin Hashim. The funds were used for procuring explosive materials and other resources for the Coimbatore blast.

The financial crimes probe agency informed the court that the interrogation of the accused is necessary to "unearth the complete modus operandi and money trail". It sought four days of questioning for Hidayatullah and Faaruq; and six days for Hanifa and Rahman.

NIA, which is the predicate offence agency in the case, while calling ED a 'third party', argued in the court that it has "no objection for the ED to interrogate and record the statements of the

accused persons" provided that its chief investigating officer (CIO) along with his team is "given access to the interrogation session" so that any new facts disclosed during the course of investigation shall be used to analyze whether any fresh inputs emerge from NIA's point of view as part of further investigation in this case. It further claimed that its presence won't be detrimental to ED's investigations. While accepting ED's plea, the court ruled in its order on September 10 that it was "not inclined to permit" NIA to join the ED interrogation.

A senior government official, who didn't want to be named, said "Indian criminal procedure does not contain a provision which expressly authorises two independent investigation agencies to jointly interrogate an accused, especially when they have separate first information reports (FIRs). It can only happen either through a court order or orders are issued officially by the state or central government a joint team, special investigation team (SIT), etc, which is not there so far in the Coimbatore blast probe". "We have seen this happen unofficially so many times," he added.

A second official said, "the NIA could have always asked ED later to share its interrogation details unofficially".

'Islamic prayers': HC relief to shunted teacher

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court has granted relief to a teacher who was suspended over students' uniforms and allegations that students at the school were performing Islamic prayers. Justice Manju Rani Chauhan disposing of a petition filed by the teacher, Mohd Anzar Ahmad, directed that the departmental inquiry against him must be concluded at the earliest preferably within 15 days and till the conclusion of inquiry, the suspension order shall remain in abeyance.

Pb man suicide: Pilot, Warring detained during Cong protest

CHANDIGARH: Congress leader Sachin Pilot, state party chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and other leaders were detained by police on Tuesday during a protest to demand finance minister Harpal Singh Cheema's removal over the alleged suicide of a Dalit man. The protesters also demanded an independent probe into the incident, tried to march towards Cheema's house.

SC gives Rajpal Yadav two weeks to deposit ₹2 crore

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed actor Rajpal Yadav to furnish ₹2 crore within two weeks as part of a criminal prosecution in several cheque bounce cases even as the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant-headed bench said it had no faith in him looking at his past conduct before the Delhi High Court, which had sentenced him to three months imprisonment.

Govt to brief JPC on FCRA bill in 1st meet

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NEW DELHI: The Union home ministry will brief a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) on September 18 on the proposed amendments to the foreign contributions bill, after stiff objections from several stakeholders forced the government to delay the bill's passage in Parliament. JPC chairman and BJP MP from Paschim Champaran Sanjay Jaiswal told HT, "I am open to every suggestion. I will take every member into confidence and we will take all decisions collectively."

The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, allows a Centre-appointed authority to take over assets created through foreign donations

THE 31-MEMBER JPC WAS FORMED BY THE LS SPEAKER ON SEPTEMBER 3, AND ITS FIRST MEETING IS SET TO BE HELD ON SEPTEMBER 18

if an organisation fails to retain its FCRA licence.

Many Opposition parties, including the Congress, church bodies and other organisations, have opposed the provision, arguing that it goes against the rights of minority institutions to receive charity.

A senior member of the panel said the home ministry, the nodal ministry for the bill, will

brief the JPC on various aspects of the legislation at its first meeting.

"The members may also draw up a list of experts and organisations to depose before the panel in subsequent meetings," the member said on the condition of anonymity.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla constituted the 31-member JPC on September 3 to review the bill, more than three weeks after the proposal to send the controversial legislation to a parliamentary panel was accepted by the Lower House.

The panel has 14 BJP MPs, including Jaiswal and a total of 19 National Democratic Alliance lawmakers. The Telugu Desam Party, Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party have one member each, and the Janata Dal

(United) has two members. Three nominated members who had joined the BJP — C Sadanandan Master, former external affairs secretary Harsh Vardhan Shringla, and criminal lawyer Ujjwal Deora Nikam — are also part of the panel.

The Congress has five berths. The Samajwadi Party, Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) and Indian Union Muslim League have one member each. The Trinamool Congress — both of them loyal to Mamata Banerjee — and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) have two members each in the panel. No member of the rebel TMC group has been included.

The Lok Sabha referred the FCRA amendment bill to the JPC on August 12 for an extensive review.

CRPF REVOKES SUSPENSION OF DIG OVER POST

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NEW DELHI: The CRPF has revoked the suspension of DIG Bidhan Chandra Patra, who was suspended in June and faced an inquiry for allegedly sharing audio and video messages on social media calling for "changing the government established by law" while protesting the Centre's move to enact the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Act, 2026.

An official said Patra was informed of his reinstatement on Tuesday after the inquiry examined the allegations against him, including whether he had violated the Official Secrets Act. The CRPF did not comment on the matter.



Union ministers Amit Shah and CR Patil, along with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma, Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Dhami, Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath, Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini, in New Delhi on Tuesday. @BHAJANLALBJP-X

6 states sign MoU for Kishau dam project

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NEW DELHI/SHIMLA/CHANDIGARH/DEHRADUN: Six Yamuna basin states on Tuesday signed a memorandum of agreement for the long-pending Kishau Multipurpose dam project in Himachal Pradesh's Sirmour district, with Union home minister Amit Shah describing the pact as a "historic agreement".

The chief ministers of Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan, Delhi and Haryana – Yogi Adityanath, Pushkar Singh Dhami, Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, Bhajan Lal Sharma, Rekha Gupta and Nayab Singh Saini – signed the pact in the presence of Shah and jal shakti minister CR Patil, an official statement said.

The agreement aims to strengthen water security, power generation, irrigation and drinking water supply in the six states, besides contributing to the rejuvenation of the Yamuna river.

Shah said the agreement would benefit all six states in different ways and congratulated their chief ministers and Patil for helping to bring the project to this stage.

He said, "The Centre and the chief ministers of the six Yamuna basin states are committed to completing the project at the earliest."

The Kishau project envisages the construction of a 232.6-metre-high concrete gravity dam on the Tons River, which flows along the Uttarakhand-Hima-

THE PROJECT, PENDING FOR OVER 8 YRS, IS ESTIMATED TO COST AROUND ₹15,000 CRORE, AND SHAH SAID THE CENTRE WILL SHARE 90% OF THE FINANCIAL BURDEN

chal Pradesh border, with a water storage capacity of 1,562 million cubic metres.

The project will potentially irrigate 97,000 hectares of land and generate 1,476 million units of clean hydropower. Shah said, adding that Delhi would be the biggest beneficiary.

The pact comes after the six states agreed in June to sign an MoU on the project, clearing the way for its consideration by the Union cabinet. The project is estimated to cost around ₹15,000 crore and has been pending for more than eight years.

"Under the agreement, the Centre will bear approximately 90% of the financial burden, while the remaining 10% will be borne by the participating states in accordance with the 1994 agreement," said Shah.

He said an agreement reached on May 12, 1994, provided for separate agreements for each storage project coming up in the Yamuna basin.

Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath said the project would expand irrigation facilities in the state,

empower farmers, strengthen drinking-water availability and help maintain the uninterrupted flow of the Yamuna.

In a post on X, he described the agreement a reflection of "solution through cooperation" and cooperative federalism.

He said the states' joint resolve would open new avenues for water security and agricultural prosperity and give fresh momentum to the creation of "Developed Uttar Pradesh-Developed India".

"Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, a significant resolve has been realised today towards the proper utilisation of water resources and ensuring water security for future generations," Adityanath added.

Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta said, "Delhi, in particular, will receive 109.9 MCM of water under the arrangement, helping meet the capital's drinking water requirements and improve the environmental flow of the Yamuna."

"Water shortage is one of Delhi's major challenges. The progress of the Kishau project will strengthen Delhi's water security and make additional raw water available to the capital during periods of low water availability," Gupta added.

"Adequate flow is essential for the river's environmental health. The Delhi government is working at various levels to make the Yamuna clean and pristine, and the benefits of the Kishau project will further strengthen these efforts," she said.

Unused sugar import quota can be given up by Sept 30, says Centre

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NEW DELHI: The Union government has extended the deadline for sugar mills and refiners to surrender unused raw sugar import quotas till September 30, giving them more time to decide whether to go ahead with imports at a time when domestic sugar prices have fallen and global prices have risen.

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), in a public notice issued on Monday, said holders of the quota can surrender any unused quantity allocated to them by September 30. They will have to pay an amount equal to 0.5% of the value of the surrendered sugar at the time of import. This replaces the rolling 15-day window that had earlier been given to traders to surrender any quantity they did not want to use.

The decision comes less than a month after the government allowed duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar under a special quota to increase supplies and keep prices under control ahead of the festive season.

Since then, domestic prices have fallen, while global prices have risen. This means imported



The decision comes less than a month after the government allowed duty-free imports.

sugar is now more expensive than sugar available in India. "With significant correction in domestic sugar prices and with an increase in global sugar prices, there is no reason to import now," a sugar analyst, who did not want to be named, said.

The analyst said mills that received a large part of the initial allocation are likely to surrender their unused quota rather than import sugar at current international prices. The government, as per the notification, had already allocated 797,450 tonnes of the 1 million tonne quota after receiving applications from mills and refiners. Another 202,550 tonnes remained available and DGFT had invited fresh applications for this quantity earlier this month.

SC FLAYS CENTRE FOR CHALLENGING PENSION TO DISABLED SOLDIERS

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday criticised the Centre for pursuing appeals against grant of disability pension to ex-servicemen in the face of a clear recommendation by the defence minister in 2015 for immediate withdrawal of such appeals against disabled soldiers.

Dismissing a batch of over 270 appeals filed by Centre against various orders passed by the Armed Forces Tribunal (AFT) and high courts, a bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhya said, "Raksha Mantri Report of 2015 recommended the immediate withdrawal of appeals of this nature pending against disabled soldiers, a recommendation that has not been faithfully implemented."

Directing Centre to comply with the judgments granting disability pension to ex-soldiers, the court allowed the Centre four months to comply with the directions. The Raksha Mantri's report was one of the documents relied upon by the ex-servicemen seeking validation of their claims for disability pension even as the Centre denied that every ailment or disability cannot be attributable to military service.

Chase insolvency cases with large 'haircuts', ED chief tells officers

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NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) chief Rahul Navin has asked all his teams to focus on unearthing frauds in insolvency cases involving disproportionately large "haircuts" through which promoters re-acquire assets, a statement issued by the agency said on Tuesday.

At a two-day quarterly conference of the agency that started Monday, he also asked ED officers to identify red flags and initiate money laundering investigations against "masterminds" in such cases, and raised the issue of state police forces not filing cases on the agency's references.

He recommended the creation of joint teams with state police as well as using the police's powers under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) to attach properties. Navin also ordered a review of ED's requests related to international cooperation, extradition and fugitive "management".

The directive on haircuts comes days after a controversy broke out over a National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order approving Zee founder Subhash Chandra's repay-

THE ED CHIEF SAID FRAUDS UNDER IBC AND PMLA SHOULD BE UNEARTHED BY DIFFERENT ZONES

ment plan of only ₹6.5 crore for loans he gave personal guarantee against admitted claims of ₹22,000 crore. The decision was stayed by a larger NCLT bench. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has booked Chandra over a mismatch in stated income while standing guarantee for a loan from LIC Housing Finance and during insolvency proceeding after the loan went into default. ED is also set to soon file a case in the matter, according to officials.

Outlining the core operational thrust areas for ED in the coming days, Navin said that the zones should unearth "frauds under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) and the PMLA (prevention of money laundering act), including re-examination of collusive resolution cases involving disproportionately large haircuts through which promoters re-acquire assets", the statement said.

Probe widens into Karnataka fake drug racket

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BENGALURU: The first clue in Karnataka's suspected fake drug racket was found not in a hospital or pharmacy, in a field.

A labourer in C K Tandy village near Doddari in Ramanagara district noticed discarded medicine waste, including vials, tubes and packets containing some powder. He alerted a police constable, who visited the area, collected samples and passed the information to senior officers.

The tip led investigators on August 18 to an unlicensed facility at Kurubakeranahalli, near the Bidadi toll gate. They seized medicines worth ₹4.91 crore, along with expired stock, injection filling equipment, packaging material and forged labels, superintendent of police, Ramanagara

district, R Srinivas Gowda said. Investigators suspected that cheaper medicines were being transferred into fresh vials and relabelled as expensive pharmaceutical brands. The biggest seizure comprised 5,640 vials labelled as Cefivagel 2.5 injections, which police said was priced at ₹3.38 crore.

"Some of the injectable antibiotics recovered are used against serious bacterial infections, including pneumonia, complicated urinary and abdominal infections and infections involving drug resistant bacteria," a health department official said.

Four people were arrested in the first operation: Venkatesh, proprietor of Bangalore Special Life in Chamrajpet; Tejas, the warehouse manager and a relative of R Prashant; and workers Prabhudeva Gowda and Naveen

R PRASHANT, A MEDICAL REPRESENTATIVE, EMERGED AS A KEY ACCUSED AND SUSPECTED KINGPIN, POLICE OFFICER SAID

Kumar, the SP said.

The equipment and labels provided investigators with an initial picture of the alleged operation.

Officials suspected that medicines were being transferred into new vials, relabelled and returned to the pharmaceutical supply chain. Medicines bought for around ₹600 to ₹700 a vial were allegedly sold for several

thousand rupees after relabelling.

The scale of the seizure led to a warning by Health and Family Welfare Minister UT Khader: "If one day we get almost ₹5 crore worth of fake drugs, I wonder how many crores worth of fake drugs are already among people."

R Prashant, a medical representative linked to the Bidadi premises, emerged as a key accused and suspected kingpin, according to police. Investigators later learnt that he had left India for Azerbaijan, they added.

The inquiry took another turn on September 11, when the SIT and Drugs Control Department raided Krupa Healthcare near Minerva Circle in Bengaluru. Its owner, licensed pharmacist Veeresh Kumar Jain, was arrested.

The suspected distribution network was believed to have

reached more than 90 hospitals and clinics in Bengaluru, while more than 15 medical representatives came under scrutiny.

On Tuesday, Karnataka government had shared the inventory of suspected spurious and counterfeit medicines with the Union government and other states.

Hospitals, nursing homes and other clinical establishments were directed not to administer medicines identified in the seizures.

The state health minister said he has written to the Union health minister seeking the deputation of a central drug surveillance officer to assist in the investigation.

"Since the value of the seized drugs exceeds ₹5 crore, the Centre may also order a CBI probe," he added.

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Pak’s bounty on Jaish chief Azhar ‘gimmick’, says MEA

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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday urged Pakistan to take action against sanctioned terrorists based on its soil instead of resorting to “gimmicks” such as a “phony announcement” of a bounty for Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) chief Masood Azhar.

Pakistan has maintained a bounty of Pakistani ₹7 million for Azhar for several years, and he is wanted by India for several terror attacks, including the 2001 Parliament strike, the 2016 Pathankot airbase assault, and the 2019 Pulwama bombing.

Azhar was freed by India along with two other terrorists in exchange for the passengers on flight IC 814 that was hijacked from Kathmandu to Kandahar in December 1999. He is also listed among the most-wanted terrorists in the “Red Book” of Pakistan’s Federal Investigation Agency’s (FIA).

“All that I would say is that such gimmicks and hoodwinking by Pakistan is nothing new. We have seen similar gimmicks in the past as well,” external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told a regular media briefing when he was asked about

‘Strikes on merchant shipping and civil infra unacceptable’

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday reiterated its opposition to attacks on merchant shipping and civilian infrastructure amid the West Asia conflict and said strikes on Saudi Arabia’s economic assets by Yemen’s Houthi rebels undermine regional stability and navigation through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in the context of an attack on an oil tanker off the coast of Oman that left an Indian seafarer missing that the targeting of commercial shipping, mariners, civilians and civilian infrastructure in West Asia is unacceptable to India. The issue of Houthi strikes on Saudi Arabia figured in a meeting between EAM S Jaishankar and his Saudi counter-



Randhir Jaiswal

part, Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, on the margins of the Brics Summit on Sunday.

Jaiswal responded to a question on an attack on the Panama-flagged oil tanker MT El Gaia that left an Indian crew missing off the coast of Oman on Sunday by saying that all such strikes are unacceptable. “Let me say that targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers, civilians and civilian infrastructure in the region is unacceptable to us,” he said. **HTC**

Pakistan’s bounty for Azhar.

“For a state sponsor of terrorism to make phoney announcements, we all know how hollow it is. Pakistan must take action and

not make phoney announcements, which are of no consequence,” he said.

While Pakistani authorities have claimed that they are una-

ware of Azhar’s whereabouts and that he has fled to Afghanistan. New Delhi has accused Islamabad of sheltering the JeM chief. Several of Azhar’s relatives were killed during an Indian strike on the JeM’s main base at Bahawalpur in May 2025 in retaliation for the Pahalgam terror attack.

The Taliban regime too has rejected Pakistan’s claim that Azhar is in Afghanistan.

Pakistan’s reiteration of the reward for information on Azhar came in the face of pressure from the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) to crack down on terror groups and their leaders. The global watchdog is set to review Pakistan’s anti-terrorism efforts at a plenary meeting next month.

Pakistan was placed on the FATF’s “grey list” of countries subject to enhanced monitoring during 2018-2022 for its failure to counter terror financing, particularly by JeM and Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT). The pressure from FATF and Western countries forced Pakistan to take several steps against leaders of both terror groups.

Azhar was designated as a global terrorist by the UN Security Council in May 2019 after China removed a block to his listing.

INDIA-US JOINT MILITARY DRILLS IN U’KHAND, RAJ

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NEW DELHI: India and the US on Tuesday began joint military exercise “Yudh Abhyas” which is being conducted simultaneously at Auli in Uttarakhand and the Mahajan field firing range near Bikaner, the Indian Army said.

“The exercise is aimed at enhancing the joint military capability of both armies for employment of integrated battle groups (IBG) in mountainous and semi-mountainous terrain, with emphasis on infantry-dominated operations. It will strengthen interoperability, facilitate exchanges of best operational practices and strengthen joint planning and execution,” it said in a statement.

The training will include the employment of drones and autonomous systems for surveillance and reconnaissance as well as demonstration of contemporary weapon systems, the army said.

The US Army, in a statement, said the two-week drills will focus on readiness, interoperability and cooperation.

‘3k cases in 180 days’: SC questions ED over PMLA adjudication

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday questioned the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on the practice of allowing a single member of the PMLA adjudicating authority to decide cases involving attachment of properties, asking whether there could be genuine application of mind when thousands of matters had to be dealt with within the statutory 180-day period.

“Will there be real application of mind or signing on the dotted lines?” the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant-led bench asked during a hearing on whether a single member, particularly one without judicial experience, could confirm provisional property attachments made by ED under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The bench, also comprising justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, reserved its verdict but directed ED to furnish details of the number of attachment orders issued by it and the time taken by the adjudicating authority to dispose of challenges to such orders.

The bench underlined that attachment of property under PMLA has serious civil consequences and cannot be treated as a routine administrative exercise. “But it does have civil consequences on possession and right to enter the property,” it told ED, rejecting an argument that a provisional attachment order merely prohibits transfer of the property and does not determine criminality.

The court was hearing a batch of petitions questioning the functioning of adjudicating authorities under PMLA. One of the petitions, filed by M/s Karvy Realty (India) Ltd, challenges a 2024 Telangana high court ruling which held that a single-member adjudicating authority could exercise powers under Section 8 of PMLA even if that member did not have legal experience.

Section 6 of PMLA provides for an adjudicating authority comprising a chairperson and two members with expertise in law, administration or finance. It also permits the chairperson to constitute benches of one or two members in specified circumstances.

The petitioners argued that the statutory scheme contemplated a



SC was hearing a batch of pleas questioning adjudicating authorities under PMLA.

judicial element in the adjudication of attachment proceedings, particularly since the SC upheld PMLA’s constitutional validity in Vijay Madanlal Choudhary Vs Union of India (2022) while taking note of the safeguards built into the adjudicatory mechanism.

The court’s concern, however, centred on whether the statutory 180-day timeline could undermine the quality of adjudication if a single member was required to handle a large volume of proceedings.

“Can you imagine the pressure put on the tribunal to look into 3,000-5,000 cases within six months? Will there be real application of mind or signing on the dotted lines?” the bench asked.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for one of the petitioners, said the adjudicating authority had for a considerable period functioned with only a single member. He referred to data on the authority’s website showing 8,851 cases had been initiated by ED, of which only 60 reached trial, and said there were over 3,000 attachment orders. “The intent of the legislature is bestowed on one tribunal and attachment is the heart and soul of any investigation under PMLA. Will it not make the power illusory as there would hardly be any application of mind?” the bench asked.

ED disputed the figures cited by the petitioners. Additional solicitor general Anil Kaushik said the figure of 3,000 attachment orders did not represent 3,000 distinct cases as there could be multiple attachment orders in the same matter. He said that only 461 attachment orders had been issued between April 1, 2024 and March 31, 2025.

The bench nonetheless said: “Even if 100 matters are there, why should only one member adjudicate? This involves people’s property. It needs to be expeditiously decided.”

SENT BACK FROM CANADA, LAWRENCE AIDE HELD IN DELHI

CHANDIGARH: A close associate of jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi was taken into custody at the IGI Airport in Delhi on Tuesday after being deported from Canada, Punjab Police said.

The arrest of Karamveer Singh, a resident of Bahadur Ke village in Ludhiana, by Punjab Police’s Anti-Gangster Task Force (AGTF) is being seen as a major breakthrough against transnational organised crime.

The development comes close on the heels of Punjab Police securing the extradition of fugitive criminal Amritpal Singh alias Amrit Dalam, a key operative of the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria gang, from the Republic of Moldova.

Karamveer Singh had provided logistical support and a hideout to Anmol Bishnoi in the #USA. He was wanted in FIR registered at PS (police station) State Crime, SAS Nagar, under relevant sections of the IPC, Arms Act and Passport Act. A Look Out Circular (LOC) was initiated by AGTF Punjab on 03.09.2026,” Director General of Police (DGP) Gaurav Yadav said in a post on X.

The DGP said that the Look Out Circular was initiated by the AGTF on September 3.

Anmol Bishnoi is Lawrence Bishnoi’s younger brother. **PTI**

BODIES OF WOMAN, HUSBAND FOUND TIED TO TREES IN U.P.

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MEERUT: A 36-year-old woman and her 40-year-old husband were found dead at two separate locations, around 1.5 km apart in Uttar Pradesh’s Bijnor district on Tuesday, with their bodies tied to trees in unusual circumstances, a police officer said.

The couple, residents of Jalapur Kazi village under Bijnor Kotwali police station, had gone to collect wood on Monday, additional superintendent of police (ASP) Krishna Gopal Singh said. Singh said when they did not return, family members alerted the police.

On Tuesday, their bodies were found tied to trees 1.5 km apart, the ASP said, adding that the probe is on.

LCA trainer, Dhruv NG delivery on Sept 18

Rahul Singh

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NEW DELHI: Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) will hand over two light combat aircraft (LCA Mk-1) trainers to the Indian Air Force on September 18, marking the completion of a contract signed in 2010, people aware of the matter said on Tuesday. The state-run plane maker will also deliver four Dhruv NG helicopters to Pawan Hans the same day, as it sharpens its focus on the civil aviation business, the people said. The helicopter service provider ordered 10 such multi-role helicopters in January.

The trainers and helicopters will be delivered in the presence of defence minister Rajnath Singh and civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu.

HAL’S DELIVERY OF THE TWO LIGHT COMBAT AIRCRAFT TRAINERS WILL MARK COMPLETION OF A CONTRACT SIGNED IN 2010

IAF ordered 40 LCA Mk-1s in the initial operational clearance (IOC) and the more advanced final operational clearance (FOC) configurations — the first variants of the LCA.

The IOC contract for 20 aircraft was signed in 2006 for completion by 2011 and the FOC contract for another 20 aircraft was inked in 2010 for completion by 2016. The initial LCA orders comprised 32 single-seater jets and

eight twin-seat trainers. The fighters and six trainers are already in service, split between two LCA squadrons.

The last two FOC trainers that will be delivered to the IAF feature enhanced radar performance, improved autopilot handling, upgraded fuel systems and avionics software, along with software defined radio (SDR) for secure communications, the people said.

Also, IAF has placed two separate orders for a total of 180 LCA Mk-1As with a combined value of ₹1.1 lakh crore to shore up its fighter fleet. The first contract for 83 jets was inked in February 2021, followed by a second one for 97 fighters in September 2025.

The remaining six twin-engine Dhruv NG helicopters are expected to be delivered in the

current financial year. The development comes as HAL targets deriving 25% of its turnover from non-military business over the next decade; the figure currently stands at 5%. The Dhruv NG builds on the advanced light helicopter (ALH) programme, with earlier technical glitches and safety concerns now addressed. To be sure, ALH Dhruv’s earlier variants are operated by the three services and the coast guard.

HAL’s internal estimates suggest that India will require around 400 helicopters in the Dhruv NG category in the coming years.

HAL is also set to deliver the first batch of delayed HTT-40 basic trainer aircraft to the IAF. The IAF ordered 70 basic trainers for ₹6,838 crore three years ago to train its rookie pilots.

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Govt suspends ops by flying school operator

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NEW DELHI: The civil aviation ministry on Tuesday suspended the operations of Kanpur-based flying training organisation (FTO) Garg Aviation "until further notice", following a series of complaints alleging safety and regulatory violations at the flight school, multiple people aware of the matter told HT.

Garg Aviation was recently involved in a fatal crash in which a pilot and an instructor were killed in Kanpur on August 27. Separately, a trainee pilot was injured following a landing incident in June, according to people aware of the matter.

"The DGCA (Directorate General of Civil Aviation) has suspended the FTO's operations on the ministry's direction," a civil

aviation ministry official told HT.

"It is also learnt that the FTO was not conducting any operations for a few days. The DGCA will look into the concerns in detail," the officer added.

The action comes after the Associations of Flight training Organisation (AFTO) wrote to civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu and civil aviation secretary Samir Kumar Sinha on Tuesday seeking a monitored investigation into its allegations against Garg Aviation.

The association, in its letter seen by HT, said it had submitted 14 complaints to the DGCA since November 2024, alleging several violations and non-compliances, but claimed that no "serious and transparent investigation" had been undertaken.

Garg Aviation did not respond to request for comment.

BJP edges Cong by narrow margin in Rajasthan civic body elections

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JAIPUR: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has won the 2026 Rajasthan urban local body elections by a margin of 0.94 percentage points against the Congress, highlighting a closely fought polls in the state.

Across 309 urban local bodies and 10,244 wards, the BJP secured 35.18% of the votes against 34.24% for the Congress.

The margin is the second narrowest between the BJP and Congress in Rajasthan's civic elections since 2019. Only the 2021 polls were closer, when the Congress led the BJP by 0.67 percentage points — 34.23% against 33.56%.

The BJP's 2026 vote share is also substantially below the

ACROSS 309 URBAN LOCAL BODIES AND 10,244 WARDS, THE BJP SECURED 35.18% OF THE VOTES AGAINST 34.24% VOTE SHARE OF THE CONGRESS

42.49% it secured in the 2020 municipalities and municipal councils elections, while the Congress's 34.24% is only marginally lower than its 34.23% share in 2021.

Even in the 2020 elections to the Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota municipal corporations, the Congress held a 2.27-point advantage over the BJP, polling 40.08% against 37.81%.

For the Congress, the narrow

gap in the latest polls provides some political reassurance.

Despite being out of power in the state since 2023, the party has managed to retain a statewide urban vote base broadly comparable to that of the BJP.

Political analyst Manish Godha said the near-dead heat between the two parties becomes even more significant in the context of the independent vote, which accounted for more than a quarter of the statewide vote.

"This indicates that the civic contest was not simply a two-party battle. Local candidates, rebel nominees and independent contestants continued to command a substantial share of the electorate, potentially influencing outcomes in closely fought wards."

SC SEEKS CENTRE'S STAND ON 1-MNTH EXTENSION FOR TRIBUNAL MEMBERS

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday told the Centre to take instructions on whether the retiring members across tribunals be permitted to continue for one-month as a stop gap arrangement till fresh appointments are made under the newly introduced Tribunal Reforms Act.

Posting the matter on Wednesday, the court asked Attorney General R Venkataramani to take instructions if the current posts where members and chairpersons are retiring are allowed to continue for a further period of one month or such time till the new appointments are carried out.

"We do not want a situation where tribunals become defunct," a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said while allowing day for the AG to come back with a response.

The court had earlier permitted retiring members to continue till September 8 and when this period got over last week, the Union government was directed to ensure new appointments are carried out at the earliest.

However, on Tuesday, several bar associations of tribunals pointed out that the working of certain tribunals has been impacted due to the retirement of members and requested the court to allow them to continue for the time being.

Venkataramani said the Centre does not want such ad-hoc arrangements to continue as it poses hindrance in the fresh appointments.

The bench, also comprising justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said, "You need to give us a definite assurance that the posts will be filled up. Till that is done, we want the current arrangement (of extension) to work as a stop-gap arrangement and be coterminous with the fresh appointments to be made."



Use AI to make Sanskrit more engaging: FM

CHENNAI: Pitching for the use of AI to make Sanskrit more engaging, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday said that technology should go beyond teaching grammar to help learners appreciate the literary richness and beauty of classical texts. Speaking at the launch of the AI-based Large Language Model (LLM) 'Sanskrit Heritage Model' at the Madras Sanskrit College, she said, "Language has to be tempting enough for people to learn."

FDA suspends licence of Mumbai's Cafe Mondegar

MUMBAI: The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) on Tuesday said in a statement that it has suspended the licences of Cafe Mondegar, a popular restaurant, and three other food establishments in Mumbai after inspections found serious food safety and hygiene violations.

Leopard poaching: SC to hear Wildlife SOS chief's plea

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to urgently hear a plea by Wildlife SOS co-founder and CEO Kartick Satyanarayan, who faces arrest in a Madhya Pradesh case involving the alleged poaching of leopards. CJI Surya Kant agreed to expedite the listing of two petitions filed by him.

OPENAI VS ANI: HC REFUSES ANY EX-PARTE ORDER

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Tuesday refused to immediately restrain OpenAI from scraping news agency ANI's content to train ChatGPT and generate responses, saying the company must first be heard.

"We will not like to pass any order ex parte without hearing the other side," a division bench of justices Avneesh Jhingna and Manmeet PS Arora told ANI's lawyer, Siddhant Kumar.

The court was hearing ANI's appeal against a July 24 order of a single judge, who dismissed the agency's plea seeking to restrain OpenAI from using its content to train ChatGPT. The judge held that OpenAI's use of such material falls within the exception of "fair dealing" under Indian copyright law.

Keralam drafts bill to improve geriatric care

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A draft legislation is in the works that proposes fixing of quality standards and responsibilities of assisted living facilities, home care agencies and government homes housing for the elderly in Keralam and building a framework for geriatric care, the chief minister's office said on Tuesday. Chief minister VD Sathesnan, chairing a meeting to review the draft Keralam State Elderly Persons (Care and Protection) Bill, 2026, in Thiruvananthapuram, directed officials to expedite the procedures associated with drafting the legislation.

According to the CMO, "One of the main objectives is developing the caregiving sector into a

professional system. For this, a framework for geriatric care certification will be formed. Caregivers would be given training and certification. Their backgrounds would be checked and a state-wide registry will be developed. This will help create jobs for skilled caregivers." It added that the government was committed to building a "silver economy" — services catering to senior citizens — in the state that would tie the rising needs of elderly people with the new economic and employment opportunities.

Figures from the Registrar General of India have stated that the population of those aged 60 and above in Keralam is expected to rise to one-fourth of the state's population in less than a decade.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



INDIA-CHINA TIES

basis" for developing ties with China as both leaders welcomed "steady progress" in bilateral relations.

"Prime Minister referred to Indian concerns as well, and underlined those, that both sides should show sensitivity to each other's core concerns and be guided by three mutuals — mutual respect, mutual interest and mutual sensitivity," external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told a regular media briefing. He did not go into details regarding India's concerns.

Jaiswal was responding to a question on the opposition Congress party's contention that the Indian side had weakened its position on border transgressions by China while deepening economic dependence on Beijing.

The spokesperson acknowledged that issues such as Taiwan and Tibet had figured in the discussions between the two leaders, as had been pointed out in a Chinese readout on the meeting.

The Chinese readout had said that India's position on issues related to Taiwan and Tibet "remain unchanged", and that the Indian side "will not allow any force to engage in anti-China activities on its territories". People familiar with the matter said both sides had raised their concerns during the talks, with India taking up the need to maintain peace and tranquillity along the border.

Modi and Xi met against the backdrop of fresh tensions between Indian and Chinese troops in the remote Taksing region of Arunachal Pradesh, with reports of face-offs in July and August.

The talks were also an opportunity to take stock of several rounds of dialogue of the Special Representatives on the border issue, the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) and senior military commanders. India and China held the first round of talks between military commanders in the eastern sector in Arunachal Pradesh on September 6 and 7.

Jaiswal was also asked about Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi's remarks that Modi and Xi had reached an "important consensus" that India and China should be partners, and he replied that the Indian side had already issued a detailed readout on the discussions.

At his meeting with Xi, Modi emphasised that peace and tranquillity in the border areas "remains an essential basis for the

continued development of bilateral relations". He further underlined that both sides should "observe existing agreements and understandings on border related issues".

The two leaders "expressed commitment to a fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question proceeding from the political perspective of their overall bilateral relations", the external affairs ministry said.

Modi and Xi welcomed the "steady progress" in India-China relations since their last meeting at Tianjin in August 2025, and said differences should not become disputes between the two countries.

Besides the border issue, India has a range of concerns, especially in the economic sphere, including China's visa curbs, export restrictions on critical machinery and commodities, and the imbalance in two-way trade.

Xi said his two meetings with Modi since 2024, when the two sides reached an understanding on being the standoff in Ladakh, have guided bilateral ties from a "restart" to a "further enhancement". Xi listed four points for promoting bilateral ties — China and India are partners, not rivals; both sides should focus on development, strengthening friendly exchanges and mutually beneficial cooperation; they should commit to parallel development and mutual promotion of bilateral relations and border issues; and benefit the world through inclusive multilateral cooperation.

META MOVE ON CSEAM

apparent child sexual exploitation to the US-based National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC), which works with law enforcement authorities around the world. NCMEC shares India-related reports with the National Crime Records Bureau under a 2019 agreement.

The government wants Meta to report such cases to Indian authorities directly as well. "The point is that Meta has been reporting to NCMEC, but we want that Meta reports it to Indian law enforcement agencies as well," the MeitY official said.

In a message sent to select journalists, a government official, who asked not to be named, said Meta had agreed to report child-safety matters to the appropriate law enforce-

ment agencies. "It is a first step towards making the platforms safe for children and much more needs to be done," the message said. It added that the government was engaging with other platforms to identify and remove such content, and would "take action against platforms which do not take proactive steps for the safety of children".

The government's messaging described children's online safety as a fundamental principle for any social media platform operating in India, and as "non-negotiable".

NCPCR, the country's apex child rights body, took suo motu cognisance of the BBC findings and opened an enquiry into Meta. The commission asked the company to explain why it did not inform the police after allegedly becoming aware that CSAM was being promoted on Instagram, citing obligations under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pocso) Act.

Section 19 of the Act requires anyone who knows that an offence under the law has been committed, or apprehends that one is likely to be committed, to inform the Special Juvenile Police Unit or the local police.

The commission summoned Meta India managing director Arun Srinivas to a hearing on September 9, and has summoned him again for Wednesday, a government official told HT late on Tuesday.

"NCPCR's persistent follow-up on the CSEAM [child sexual exploitation and abuse material] matter has prompted Meta to revise its policy on reporting child sexual abuse cases. Meta has now begun reporting such cases to the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) as well," the official said.

NCPCR is also drafting a uniform, voluntary code of conduct for social media platforms to strengthen safeguards for children online. The guidelines are expected to cover age-appropriate access, harmful content, recommendation algorithms, age verification and privacy.

"Mere reporting will not suffice," said NS Nappinai, a Supreme Court senior advocate and founder of the cyber-safety platform Cyber Saathi. She said Meta would have to take down such content and use technology to stop CSAM spreading through its platforms, and that

the government needed to consider action against CSAM circulated through advertisements.

"Mere reporting or take-downs do not address this serious issue," she said.

UPI TRANSACTION FEES

models and category caps.

The ministry also clarified that no transaction fee, platform fee or other charge can be imposed on individuals sending or receiving money through UPI. Small merchants, including street vendors and neighbourhood shops, receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month through UPI QR codes under the person-to-person-merchant (P2PM) category will continue to be covered by the zero-MDR framework.

Further, auto-debit recurring payments like utility bills or mutual fund subscriptions, known as UPI Mandates or AutoPay, will not carry the prescribed MDR transaction charges.

The new MDR framework and threshold structure will come into effect from 15 October, giving acquiring banks, payment aggregators, fintech applications and corporate accounting platforms time to update their software engines and billing systems, according to the statement. India's UPI platform processed 241.6 billion transactions worth ₹314.2 lakh crore in FY26, up 30% from a year earlier in volume and 21% in value. UPI had more than 55 crore users as of August 2026, according to NPCI data.

The platform processed 24.5 billion transactions worth ₹29.8 lakh crore in August 2026, up 22% in volume and 20% in value from a year earlier. P2M transactions accounted for 30% of total UPI transaction value in August, with transactions of up to ₹500 accounting for 16% and those between ₹501 and ₹2,000 for 17%.

In volume terms, P2M transactions accounted for 63% of UPI transactions, of which 86% were below ₹500 and another 10% were between ₹501 and ₹2,000, according to the latest NPCI data.

Transactions above ₹2,000 in essential and thin-margin sectors, including railways, telecommunications, insurance, fuel, utility-bill payments, educational fees and agricultural inputs, will attract a flat MDR of ₹5 per transaction. Payments relating to mutual funds, securities, stockbrokers and dealers

will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300 per transaction.

The ministry clarified that MDR is neither a tax nor a charge collected by the government or NPCI. It will instead be distributed among ecosystem participants, including banks, payment service providers and UPI application providers.

According to the NPCI FAQ, the MDR will be used to invest in infrastructure resilience, innovation, cybersecurity and customer service. The intent is to keep UPI accessible and convenient for everyday transactions while supporting the long-term sustainability of the ecosystem.

Individuals will continue to have unlimited free usage of UPI, with no monthly quotas, volume restrictions or tiered caps on free transactions.

The UPI MDR is structured to be much lower than traditional card-based transaction fees. Standard credit card MDRs typically range from 1.5% to 2.5% per transaction, while debit card MDRs are capped at up to 0.90%.

"UPI remains the most affordable digital payment acceptance tool for commercial enterprises. This cost difference helps merchants lower their payment processing expenses while accepting digital transactions," NPCI said.

NPCI also notified that 5% of the total MDR earned will be set aside in a dedicated fund for small merchants. The fund will be used to subsidize and accelerate digital payment infrastructure in Tier 3-6 centres, including the North-East states, Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh, as well as in Tier 1 and 2 centres.

The fund will also support some notified central government schemes.

"This fund will also be utilized to extend financial assistance to the ecosystem players for merchant onboarding and incentivize growth of UPI transactions among existing small merchants," NPCI said.

The fund will provide incentives for UPI transactions originating from small merchants, particularly in rural areas and Tier 3 centres and beyond, to encourage sustained usage, increase digital payment penetration and accelerate the inclusion of small businesses in the digital payments ecosystem.

The detailed framework for the fund will be finalized in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India within the next three months.

WEST ASIA CONFLICT

Crude oil should be flowing through the pipeline within days, U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright told CNBC on Tuesday.

A Saudi-led military coalition fighting against the Houthis in Yemen said 13 civilians had been wounded in the Houthis' attacks on Saudi Arabia on Monday. The Iran-backed fighters launched a lightning advance along Yemen's western coast last week, culminating in the seizure of an island in the mouth of the Red Sea.

The escalation in a new theatre in the Middle East conflict has strengthened Iran's hand in its war with the U.S. and further jeopardised global oil supplies.

Officials from a Saudi-backed Yemeni government, which is based in the south of the country and opposes the Houthis, said the Saudi and Yemeni air forces had been responding to Houthi advances by stepping up aerial bombardment of Houthi targets. That included strikes near the historic Red Sea port of Mocha, which the fighters captured last week.

But the Yemeni officials acknowledged that the Houthis had now taken effective control over almost the entire western coast of the country along the Red Sea. "The Houthis are being put under heavy pressure. They in turn are putting more and more pressure on the Saudis, increasing their campaign of missile and drone attacks," one of the Yemeni officials said.

Saudi Arabia's 1,200-km (745-mile) East-West Pipeline, which links its Gulf oil fields to the Red Sea, has been the Kingdom's principal export route while shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has been disrupted by six months of war.

Since the pipeline was shut after Friday's attack, traders say a prolonged closure could cut off as much as 4% of global oil supply. Riyadh has not said when operations might resume, but Wright said on the sidelines of a G20 energy meeting in Houston that he thought "it will be measured in days."

He said Saudi Arabia was taking steps to move more oil out of the Strait of Hormuz with assistance from the U.S. military. The new Houthi presence in the Bab el-Mandeb, or "Gate of Tears", the strait at the mouth of the Red Sea, could further jeopardise that crucial export route.

Cong attacks Centre over UPI fees move

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NEW DELHI: The Congress on Tuesday accused the government of breaking its own promise of keeping the United Payment Interface free of fees after a notification issued the day before paved the way for a Merchant Discount Rate charge on UPI transactions above ₹2,000.

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said the move breaks the government's promise of a free UPI system and accused it of "surrendering to American pressure" on digital payments. "The Modi government's loot has now reached UPI," Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge said in a statement. "No fees on UPI has been changed to 'no fees on UPI transactions up to ₹2,000.'"

On Tuesday evening, the government introduced a 0.4% transaction fee on payments above ₹2,000, capped at ₹300 for payments of ₹75,000 and above, from October 15, while explicitly ring-fencing everyday person-to-person transfers from any charge.

Reacting to the Congress statements, the BJP accused the party of spreading "fake news" to create panic about UPI transaction charges and derail Digital India. BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari called the opposition party a "jhooth ki dukaan (shop of lies)" and said the government has made it absolutely clear that MDR charges will not be levied on trans-

actions between individuals. He said 96 per cent of UPI merchant (P2M) transactions are ₹2,000 or below, and they are 100 per cent charge-free. "Even if these transactions account for just 5% of the volume, they make up nearly 65% of UPI's total transaction value," Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X. He argued that even if customers are not billed directly, the cost will still reach them. "The government says no fees will be charged to customers. But where will the fees imposed on shopkeepers ultimately come from? Added to prices, straight out of the customer's pocket." Gandhi also linked the decision to trade negotiations with Washington, arguing that the US has pushed against India's zero-MDR policy for years.

Kharge, in a post, alleged that sky-high inflation has already emptied the common person's pocket. "Wholesale inflation is near 10%, and the BJP government has planned to impose a 'Digital Payments Tax' on the public, aiming to destroy whatever little savings they have left," he said on X.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said the sequence of events that led to announcement of the MDR was "another example of Modi Govt's FAST moves (First Announce, Subsequently Think)."

Congress's media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra said the 0.4 per cent MDR on UPI transactions above ₹2,000 should be called the "Modi Tax".

MAN GETS DEATH PENALTY FOR RAPE, MURDER OF GIRL

SILCHAR: A special Pocso court in Assam's Dhubri district has sentenced a man to death for raping and killing a four-year-old girl in 2023. The court stated that the crime fell under the "rarest of rare" category.

Police said the incident took place on September 4, 2023, under Chapar Police Station limits. The accused allegedly abducted the girl, raped and strangled her to death, and threw the body in a forest area.

Bilasipara additional and district court special judge Rana Dutta awarded death penalty to accused under IPC section 302.

BISWA KALYAN PURKAYASTHA

FILE COUNTER AFFIDAVIT IN JPSC CASE BY SEPT 18: HC

RANCHI: The Jharkhand High Court on Tuesday continued its stay on the state government's order cancelling the JPSC 11-13 Civil Service and JSSC-CGL recruitment examinations, people aware of the matter said.

Justice Deepak Roshan's court slammed the state's action as arbitrary and high-handed, while criticising the sluggish Criminal Investigation Department (CID) probe, they said.

Rejecting the government's request for a four-week extension, the court granted only 48 hours to file a status report.

The next hearing is scheduled for Friday. HTc

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OPINION

The
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{ OUR TAKE }

Brace for inflation and rate hikes

Retail inflation could rise further if higher fuel prices are passed on to consumers. Not doing this for long will entail a large fiscal cost

India's retail and wholesale inflation prints for August were largely on expected lines; at the cusp of 5% and 10% respectively. On a standalone basis, the inflation numbers are not too alarming. Most analysts see inflation for the September quarter as being only slightly higher than RBI's current estimate of 4.7%.

However, the developments in the last couple of weeks should caution us against assuming a business-as-usual scenario. Crude oil prices, thanks to the rapid military advances by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen along the Red Sea coast, have caused a major disruption to Saudi oil supplies. Brent crude, the international benchmark, is already above \$100 per barrel. Its dated variants, a better indicator of the spot price, are trading even higher. Barring a resolution to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, we are looking at a prolonged disruption to the oil market.

As if an oil shock were not disruption enough, the most keenly watched interest rate in international markets, the 10-year yield on US treasuries, crossed the psychological threshold of 5% on Monday, for the first time after 2023. A *Wall Street Journal* commentary, appropriately pointed out that the 10-year yield had just gone below 4% in February when Donald Trump attacked Iran along with Israel in February. Rising oil on the back of already stubborn inflation, which is way above the Federal Reserve's 2% target, will perhaps force the new Fed chairman Kevin Warsh to hike the interest rate in the US, even if it means going against the demands of Trump. Not raising rates would risk taking bond yields even higher.

What does all this mean for the Indian economy? First is the immediate question about inflation. Retail inflation, which is also the benchmark rate for RBI, might rise further if the government passes on the burden of higher fuel prices to consumers. So far, this has not happened. Not doing it long enough will entail a large fiscal cost. As inflation inches above and if the Federal Reserve too raises interest rates, RBI will face significant pressure to increase policy rates as well. Most analysts already see this happening, although they differ on the timing and magnitude of the hikes. These differences aside, the writing on the wall is clear: Brace for higher inflation and higher interest rates.

A growing threat in the Himalayas

The recent Nepal flash floods, like the 2023 Sikkim flash floods, underline the vulnerability of Himalayan ecosystems to melting glaciers, as anthropogenic warming of the planet gathers pace and intensity. A new study quantifies the extent of damage caused to the glaciers. Systemiq, a consultancy firm, in collaboration with the Integrated Mountain Initiative, using inputs from the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) and GB Pant National Institute of Himalayan Environment, has found that Himalayan glaciers are melting 65% faster than a decade ago.

Settlements in the Himalayas, already perched on unstable surfaces, will likely face increased risks of glacier collapses and glacial lake outburst floods. In the long-term, as glaciers shrink rapidly, freshwater sources could dry up for downstream areas. For India, that means water scarcity not just in the mountains and abutting valleys, but also in the plains. Given the outsized contribution of the Himalayan river systems to the country's economy, reduced irrigation potential, loss of hydropower generation, and shrinking drinking water sources will collectively cause a serious dent.

The study highlights that black carbon (soot) is the prime culprit for accelerated melting. Settling on glacial surfaces, it causes heat to be dramatically trapped instead of getting reflected. This demands urgent mitigation efforts on carbon emissions globally. The Himalayan countries, including India, must additionally ensure lower generation of black carbon in the region by preventing forest fires, controlling vehicular traffic, and curbing the use of biomass as fuel. The crumbling Himalayas don't care for stalled policy decisions and slow changes in attitudes. They have waited long enough.

Gig workers really don't care for bleeding hearts

Gig work allows for dignity, agency over time, and is increasingly getting formalised

One thing that does not change in India is the bleeding hearts whose soft souls continue to cry for those less fortunate. Thirty years ago, they were stressing over the cruelty towards "digital coolies" who wrote code, imagined in their fertile minds as physically chained to their desks and whipped every now and then. And now the same emotion is being spent for the poor gig workers who toil hard hours, drive dangerously at great personal risk, are at the beck and call of those well-off, and are deprived of what they think are good jobs. Good jobs are, of course, another term for government jobs that require little work but come with plenty of perks. But the reality of gig workers can be very different, as it was for the coders of India. Not only were careers and livelihoods built, but the country's growth was too.

The Economic Survey 2025-26 estimates gig workers (delivery, ride-sharing, and freelancing) to be 1.2 crore in number, making up 2% of India's non-agri workforce. This will be 6.7% of India's workforce by 2029-30, contributing ₹2.35 lakh crore to the GDP. These are not small

numbers and, instead of trying to kill this industry, what would be more useful are steps to transition them into the formal economy; many such steps are already being taken.

One such example is the recent news report on how more than 50,000 Swiggy workers were helped by the platform to file tax returns. Gig workers' income is counted under the head "income from business or profession" in tax parlance and a mandatory tax is deducted at source. But, since many of them earn less than ₹12 lakh — the tax-free income threshold — they are eligible for a tax refund. However, they don't get it unless they file their returns. It is estimated that around ₹6.5 crore of refunds were facilitated by Swiggy. Tax portal Clear Tax reports that it has helped over 400,000 delivery workers file returns and unlocked ₹50 crore in tax refunds.

Filing tax returns is an important step for building a trail that will later help filers access loans, insurance, and establish a financial history. This is of real value for workers — worth much more to them than the rabble-rousers who add nothing but noise while taking away gig workers' agency over the lives that the latter have built.

Because, despite the emphatic tears and the wrinkled foreheads worrying about unfortunate gig workers, the

underlying story gets missed: that of choices and agency over time. These were the preserves of the rich so far, but are now available to those starting out. Talk to the gig workers who intersect with our lives multiple times a day, and a very different story begins to unfold. The story I hear is one of flexi-hours, the ability to control their schedule, safety of a uniform specially for women, dignity of work, and upgradation of skills.

Puja (name changed) used to work in a parlour, 8 am to 9 pm. There was one weekly off, and leaves were a hard bargain that came with a trade-off on the meagre salary. Work conditions were not great, either. The few increments she received were hard fought. She has slowly branched out and works with an aggregator now. She talks of being able to log leaves when she has an emergency at home or a festival or is ill. She speaks of skill upgrades, and of dignity.

She's not alone in this story. The several women I have spoken to who provide all kinds of services, including cooking, beauty and grooming, and cleaning, also talk about the opportunity to upgrade skills as the platforms regularly introduce them to new equipment, products, and skills. And then there is the uniform. It imparts a certain sense of dignity and keeps them safe. A woman freelancing alone is at risk of predators in homes;



Monika Halan



The Code on Social Security now formally recognises gig and platform workers and creates a framework for their social security, including schemes covering health, life, and other benefits.

SHUTTERSTOCK

but in a uniform, with the company backing them, the likelihood of incidents can be lower and there is recourse in terms of calling the company and the police.

Puja is now encouraging her husband to quit his 9-to-anytime job that has seen zero increments for over the past five years. He is planning to join a call centre (fixed hours) and drive an Uber or Ola two hours in the morning and two hours at night. He can then work on his own terms, she says, and earn more by working more — an option not possible in the current job.

At the platform level, extending life and health insurance to workers and their families, along with basic education in personal finance, will benefit the entire ecosystem. The Code on Social Security now formally recognises gig and platform workers and creates a framework for their social security, including schemes

covering health, life, and other benefits, with aggregators required to contribute to the social-security fund. The law is yet to get fully implemented, but the direction is clear. Gig workers are not going away.

At a personal level, instead of empty empathy, we, the recipient of these services, can start by just being nice to the service providers. Our lives are infinitely easier because of their work; surely, we can dignify their work? The biggest thing we need to upgrade is our attitude towards non-office work. We need to stop equating dignity with a desk, designation, and air-conditioned office. Dignifying work — whatever the work — is the missing piece of this puzzle.

Monika Halan is the best-selling author of the *Let's Talk* series of books on money. The views expressed are personal

The US's emerging contest with China in Latin America

The second Donald Trump administration's National Security Strategy highlights "enlist and expand" as the US's primary strategy to engage with Latin American countries. This seeks to end external influence in the Western hemisphere and expand the US's footprint through political influence, security, and trade. Its early progress suggests a deliberate strategy.

The US is Latin America's largest trading partner. However, China is following suit, having surpassed the US in several South American countries in trade value over the last few years. Its expansion focussed on critical minerals, infrastructure, and clean energy, grew from roughly \$296 billion in 2020 to over \$500 billion by 2024. Beijing reaffirmed this commitment to the region at the 12th China-Community of Latin American and Caribbean States (CELAC) Infrastructure Cooperation Forum in June 2026, underlining the depth of its economic influence in this part of the globe.

Faced with such engagement from Beijing and the prospects that come with it, the Trump administration appears to have accepted that the US cannot quickly outpace China on trade and investment. Instead, it aims to expand security cooperation and political alignment, while building narrower economic security leverages in critical minerals, ports, and maritime routes. These may not counter Chinese influence immediately, but they position the US to secure its interests over the long-term.

The US-led critical minerals framework highlights this approach, with 11 partner States, including four from Latin America. The framework aims at loosening Beijing's influence over critical minerals globally. It includes a guaranteed price floor for Argentine lithium and separate reciprocal trade agreements with El Salvador, Ecuador, and Argentina aimed at restricting Chinese State firms. The contested sale of Panama's canal-side ports to a consortium led by an American asset manager extends the same logic to strategic infrastructure.



Leaders such as Argentina's Javier Milei share Donald Trump's priorities on cracking down on cartels and checking migration.

GETTY IMAGES

The US's moves have had considerable impact on some Chinese interests in the region. In Panama, authorities annulled two Chinese port concessions and seized the terminals in early 2026. In Chile, the transport ministry rescinded the approval for a \$500-million China Mobile submarine cable under pressure from Washington.

Security cooperation has expanded alongside these economic measures. In April 2025, the US and Panama concluded a security pact that permits a rotational American military presence around the canal. Washington followed this up in late 2025, with arrangements with Guyana, Paraguay, Trinidad and Tobago, the Dominican Republic, and Ecuador for access to their air and naval facilities. Peru was granted a non-NATO ally status as the Trump administration approved large arms packages, including the sale of F-16s to both Peru and Argentina.

Colombia's Abelardo de la Espriella is the 7th Trump-endorsed presidential winner in the region since 2024. Leaders such as Argentina's Javier Milei, El Salvador's Nayib Bukele, and Ecuador's Daniel Noboa share Donald Trump's priorities on cracking down on cartels and checking migration. In March 2026, the Trump administration attempted to formalise this affinity through the Shield of the Americas summit, where 12 Right-wing Latin American leaders were invited with an aim to consolidate existing security ties into a single hemispheric framework against organised crime.

However, there are limits to this strategy. Despite these attempts, Chinese imports from the region reached \$146.9 billion in the first half of 2026, recording a 29.7% increase.

China's exports to Mexico also grew despite the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA) review, and the Asian nation's trade with Venezuela remained consistent even after the US intervention. Peru's China-owned Chancay port continues to grow, while Argentina approved incentives for Zijin Mining's \$709-million lithium project. China also retaliated against Panama by detaining Panamanian-flagged vessels.

The political gains for the US from its moves in the region must be similarly qualified. That support is driven mainly by domestic concerns over crime and migration rather than by any real opposition to Beijing, and most US-aligned leaders continue to court Chinese trade and investment even as they embrace Trump.

However, this alignment has not reached the public. Polling data suggests that trust in the US and President Trump in the region has worsened, while perceptions of China have remained stable. The US military actions in the region have drawn further criticism following the capture of Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro in January 2026.

All that said, Washington's immediate opportunity in Latin America cannot be ignored. A region led by likeminded leaders is more likely to grant favourable security and trade access, and growing US influence over strategic resources gives it long-term leverage. Whether this presence can eventually erode China's economic gravity is a question that is yet to be answered.

Abhishhek Kadiyala and Pracheth Thimmayya are researchers at the Takshashila Institution. The views expressed are personal

{ DMITRY PESKOV } PRESS SECRETARY, KREMLIN

We believe that space must be free of any weapon. We are counting on broad international consolidation to continue working toward the complete demilitarisation of space

Reacting to US confirmation of deployment of weapons in outer space



Misreading the 1951 Refugee Convention in India's context

The 1951 Refugee Convention recently marked its 75th anniversary, inspiring a string of commentary. One piece published in this newspaper urges India to do more and commit more, based on a treaty it has not signed. Such exhortation doesn't recognise India's actions and policies on refugee protection so far and the realities it is faced with. Since we are discussing international law, let us begin with what the Convention actually says.

The principle of non-refoulement (i.e. the obligation not to return refugees to territories where their lives or freedom are threatened) is popularly considered a universally binding norm of international law, applicable to all States regardless of whether they have signed the Convention or not.

A deeper examination shows that the principle of non-refoulement was not a pre-existing rule of customary international law that the 1951 Convention merely codified. It was created by that Convention. Its first codification deliberately restricted coverage to events occurring in Europe before January 1, 1951.

This was an intentional geographical and temporal limitation imposed on the principle, not an accident of drafting. These limitations reflected the Cold War priorities of Western States, which wanted the Convention's protection for their own refugee populations while keeping the door firmly shut against claims from the developing world. Developing country delegates objected vigorously, only to be overruled. The Eurocentric architecture of the Convention is the foundation on which the current framework rests.

The 1967 Protocol only removed the geographical limitations. It did not resolve the deeper question of whether non-refoulement had crystallised into customary international law, binding on all States. State practice, in this case, is demonstrably inconsistent. Scholars have yet to produce convincing evidence supporting a clear, consistent, and uniform State practice required for non-refoulement to be elevated to the level of customary international law. At most, non-refoulement constitutes a regional or hemispherical custom in certain extraterritorial contexts. It is not a universally binding obligation on non-signatory States.

India's non-accession to the Convention is not a gap to be managed, something that the Bangkok Principles somehow compensate. India has a distinguished record of protecting refugees that is rivalled by very few

States. But this is despite the Refugee Convention, not because of it.

India's non-accession is a well-considered sovereign choice, made at the founding of the Republic, reaffirmed consistently since, and is entirely consistent with every principle of international treaty law. States choose which treaties to join. India has chosen. That choice requires no apology and no compensation.

The Supreme Court of India has consistently held that international treaties and conventions may inform the interpretation of the Constitution, but only when India is a signatory or party to them. This doctrine reflects a fundamental principle of democratic sovereignty: The executive and Parliament, not the judiciary, decide which rules of international law the people of India wish to be bound by.

Certain high courts have departed from this principle and read non-refoulement into Article 21 of the Constitution without any doctrinal foundation. Those decisions have been correctly identified by scholars as *per incuriam* (arrived at through lack of care).

The Bangkok Principles are just as non-binding as the Refugee Convention. Citing them as evidence of India's voluntary assumption of non-refoulement-like obligations is a stretch that the text of those principles does not support.

The Rohingya migrants case is currently pending before the Supreme Court, with written arguments filed and oral hearings yet to be scheduled. The petitioners are arguing, among other things, that non-refoulement binds India as a matter of customary international law and must be read into Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

In this context, the claim that India's protection record already reflects something close to an international legal obligation is not a neutral observation. It has direct bearing on the separation of powers envisaged under our Constitution. The Supreme Court has consistently held that treaties India has not ratified cannot be read into the Constitution.

India's own record on refugees — imperfect, selective, and occasionally inconsistent, as any sovereign State's — is the product of its sovereign executive judgment responding to security concerns, regional relationships, and indigenous resources. The underpinning constitutional foundation is suited for India's needs in the current age.

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WORLD

US top court rejects Trump's mail ballot curbs for midterms

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WASHINGTON: The US Supreme Court refused to clear the Postal Service to enforce new restrictions on mail-in ballots for the congressional midterms, in a rebuff to the Trump administration after some states started early voting and opponents warned late-breaking changes would inject chaos into the elections.

The justices' decision on Monday came after North Carolina and Alabama began mailing thousands of ballots to voters and many more states prepared to do the same in the coming days. The order followed last-minute legal wrangling and uncertainty about whether states would have to suddenly upend months of planning for the November 3 midterms, when Republicans are defending their slim majority in Congress.

The Supreme Court denied the justice department's request to lift a Boston federal judge's order that barred the Postal Service from making its new mail-in ballot rules mandatory through the November contests.

In the brief, unsigned order, the court held that the Trump administration was unlikely to win the merits of its challenge to



A box of mail-in ballots at the Wake County Board of Elections in North Carolina. BLOOMBERG

the lower court's injunction and that officials failed to show that they had a stronger case for immediately reviving the rules ahead of the midterms. Justices Samuel Alito and Clarence Thomas dissented.

Trump denounces top court's decision
President Donald Trump denounced the decision in a social media post, calling it a "horrible, highly political, ruling".

He praised Alito and Thomas as "legends" and broadly criticised the top court for also ruling against his global tariffs policy and his plan to restrict birthright citizenship this year.

"It is a court that will go down as having rendered some of the most destructive, hurtful, and damaging decisions in our country's history," Trump said. Without naming them, he expressed disappointment that his appointees — Justices Neil Gorsuch, Brett Kavanaugh and Amy Coney Barrett — didn't join Alito and Thomas, saying, "these are not the people I interviewed to serve on the United States Supreme Court, they are merely a shell of their original selves".

The legal fight over whether the agency can ultimately adopt the controversial rules for future election cycles may still continue. A federal judge in Washington entered a fresh injunction blocking the contested rules on September 13, however, delivering another setback to the administration.

A coalition of Democratic state officials and voting rights groups sued to challenge the Postal Service's plan, arguing that permitting "massive changes" so late in the election cycle would be "profoundly disruptive". California Attorney General Rob Bonta said in a statement that the Supreme Court's order "is a victory for our democracy and a powerful affirmation of the rule of law".

SEVEN HASINA-ERA LEADERS GET DEATH SENTENCE IN B'DESH

DHAKA: A Bangladesh court sentenced seven senior leaders of the former ruling party, including two ex-ministers, to death in absentia on Tuesday for their role in trying to crush the 2024 uprising.

The seven men, members of ousted leader Sheikh Hasina's Awami League, were convicted of crimes against humanity including murder, as well as instigating and provoking killings.

They include the party's former general secretary, Obaidul Quader, as well as fellow former minister Mohammad Ali Arafat. They were sentenced by a three-member tribunal headed by Justice Nazrul Islam Chowdhury. "We are happy with the verdict," said prosecutor Md Aminul Islam.

The other five men are AFM Bahauddin Nasim, Sheikh Fazle Shams Parash, Mainul Hossain Khan Nikhil, Saddam Hussain and Sheikh Wali Asif Enan.

As many as 1,400 people were killed between July and August 2024, according to the UN, when Hasina's government attempted to suppress the student-led uprising. Hasina's 15-year rule ended in August 2024, when she fled her palace by helicopter to neighbouring India — where she remains in hiding.

Deployed weapons in space, reveals US

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WASHINGTON/MOSCOW: The United States has confirmed for the first time that it has deployed weapons in space, a remarkable revelation after previous warnings about countries such as Russia possibly weaponising a global frontier long agreed in treaties to be used for only peaceful purposes. Air Force Secretary Troy Meink told the Air and Space Cyber Conference in Maryland on Monday that the US has fielded "on-orbit space control weapons capable of defending the Joint Force against hostile adversary action".

Meink did not detail what the weapons were, how they work or if they were targeting other objects in space or on Earth. The US had warned two years ago that Russia was developing a new space-based, anti-satellite weapon, though the White House said the danger wasn't imminent at the time.

But reports of the anti-satellite weapon reflected longstanding worries about space threats from

U.S. FACING MUNITIONS SHORTFALL DUE TO IRAN WAR: PENTAGON

WASHINGTON: The United States is facing a shortfall in ammunition as a result of its war against Iran, the Defence Department's inspector general confirmed on Monday, contrasting with President Donald Trump's assertions of full stocks.

In a first-of-its-kind mandatory report to Congress, the inspector said that between February 28 and June 30, Operation Epic Fury (OEF) had an estimated cost of \$33.4 billion, including \$22.3 billion spent on expended munitions. AFP

one-way attack drones replacing artillery as the "primary killer". "We are increasing readiness against existing threats," he said. The revelation comes as the Trump administration puts a growing focus on space.

Russia, China criticise

Russia called on Tuesday for weapons to be kept out of space, after the US Space Force confirmed it had deployed "on-orbit space control weapons" for the first time. "We believe that space must be free of any weapon," Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters.

"We are counting on broad international consolidation to continue working toward the complete demilitarisation of space," he added.

China's foreign ministry opposed the move, warning against the "weaponisation of outer space, turning it into a battlefield, as well as an arms race there". "We urge the US side to stop expanding its military capabilities and preparing for war in outer space," ministry spokesman Guo Jiakun told a news briefing.

OPENAI, ANTHROPIC AND GOOGLE WORK TO CREATE A.I. STANDARDS BODY

WASHINGTON: The world's biggest AI companies are working on creating a standards body, ChatGPT-maker OpenAI said on Tuesday, as fears rise about the dangers of AI and pressure is on to create a safer version of the technology.

OpenAI said it was working with Anthropic and Google on an idea that originated from a proposal by Google DeepMind's Demis Hassabis for a self-regulatory body modelled after the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority that oversees US brokers and investment firms.

In July, Hassabis called for the US to create an organisation that would test the most powerful AI systems before they are released to the public.

"Funding would need to be substantial and likely mostly come from industry, in order to attract world-class technical talent and provide the necessary compute resources for large-scale testing," Hassabis wrote.

There is no consensus on how to move forward, though.

The chief of Canadian AI company Cohere recently accused the dominant American AI labs of forming a "cartel" under the guise of safety. AFP

US judge blocks visa rules for students, journos

Shashank Mattoo

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WASHINGTON: In another immigration-related legal setback for the Trump administration, a US court has blocked the government's attempt to tighten visa requirements on how long foreign students, exchange visitors and foreign journalists can study or work in America.

The new visa rules were set to go into effect on September 15, before Monday's court order postponed the date pending further legal proceedings. The successful challenge to the visa restrictions was filed by an alliance of groups of educators and unions.

Foreign students are presently

allowed to remain in the US legally so long as they maintain their student status, known as "duration of status". The Trump administration's new rules would have terminated the earlier policy and favoured a strict four-year student visa. Students who wish to stay on beyond the mandated 4 years would have to file paperwork with US Citizenship and Immigration Services. In addition, foreign students will have shorter time windows to change status or depart the US after finishing their degree programmes.

In a scathing judgment, District Court Judge F. Dennis Saylor IV took issue with the Department of Homeland Security's (DHS) conduct in providing a rationale for

the new visa rules. Judge Saylor stated that the US government had used mainly anecdotal examples to explain why the more restrictive rules were necessary to preserve national security and prevent visa abuse. The presiding judge also found that the DHS had not engaged substantially with concerns raised by educators, including the potentially devastating impact on the ability of US universities to attract top foreign students.

"The damage to the higher education system and to the economy of the United States is likely to be catastrophic. The government has acknowledged that compliance costs alone will likely total more than \$250 million in

the first year. But the real expected costs go far beyond the figure," he noted in his 48-page judgement.

Harvard University's International Office told foreign students in an advisory that the ruling preserved their present visa status without providing permanent relief, as the US government could appeal the ruling.

The court's decision was also welcomed by the plaintiffs in the case — including the Presidents' Alliance on Higher Education and Immigration and NAFSA: Association of International Educators — as a key step towards preserving America's ability to attract top foreign students.

The ruling also brings relief to

over 360,000 Indian students in the United States as well as to prospective students looking to study at American universities.

However, the Trump administration's restrictive immigration policies — including a potential \$100,000 fee for foreign students who wish to work in America through the Optional Practical Training (OPT) programme after graduation — may dampen Indian student interest in America. International student applications from India to US universities for undergraduate courses dropped 15% in the 2025-26 cycle, one of the most significant country-specific drops recorded in a report by the non-profit organisation Common App.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Goods exports jump 26% in Aug, trade gap narrows

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NEW DELHI: India's merchandise exports in August saw a robust annualised growth of over 26% to \$43.81 billion, outpacing about 14% growth in imports at \$ 70.67 billion, thus narrowing the trade deficit on the back of policy measures such as trade diversification, bilateral deals and curbs on unproductive imports of commodities like gold.

Stating that India's export growth momentum has been strong in the first four months of the current financial year, commerce secretary Rajesh Agrawal said: "Export growth momentum [has] accelerated further in August." Cumulative trade data of both merchandise and services showed that exports in the first quarter (April-June) of 2026-27 "climbed by over 13% to \$236.28 billion," he said.

Overall growth of exports (goods and services combine) accelerated further to 16.58% in July this year to \$ 82.42 billion, and by estimated 25.4% to \$82.68 billion in August, he said on Tuesday while releasing lat-

est trade data for the month. Services data for August are estimates, a conservative extrapolation of the previous month's numbers, as RBI releases figures for the services sector with a lag.

Speaking about inward shipments, he said merchandise imports in August 2026, has been at \$70.67 billion as compared to \$ 61.96 billion in the same month last year. "That means a growth of 14.1%... First time you will see, this is lower than the export growth," he said.

"And overall [goods and services] trade deficit, if you look at, it is \$9.41 billion [in August 2026] as compared to \$11.62 billion [in August] last year. So, overall trade deficit has also gone down substantially," he said.

According to experts, one of the reasons for narrowing of the trade deficit is a sharp fall in imports of gold in August 2026.

Import of gold fell by nearly 58% to \$ 2.3 billion in August 2026 as compared to \$ 5.44 billion in August 2025. Even on a sequential basis, it fell by 45% as against \$ 4.16 billion in July 2026.



Overall exports growth rose by 25.4% to \$82.68 bn in August. APF

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on May 10 urged people to avoid non-essential foreign travel and postpone gold purchases for a year. The government on May 13 raised customs duty on precious metals, including gold and silver, to 15% from 6%, to reduce imports and conserving foreign exchange for essential imports such as energy and fertilisers amid the protracted war in West Asia.

According to the commerce secretary, the trade deficit has shown a notable improvement in August 2026. Yet, the cumulative gap for first five months is higher than the last year. Speaking about surging import

demand, which led to a higher trade deficit in first five months, he said, it was also propelled by strong domestic economic expansion, rising energy requirements and the critical inputs needed to sustain the rapid growth of our manufacturing sector. India's exports are growing despite global headwinds because of conscious policy decisions such as trade diversification, ₹25,000 crore Export Promotion Mission (EPM) and free trade agreements with nearly 40 countries since 2021 such as Australia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and the United Kingdom (UK).

According to Agrawal, the India-New Zealand free-trade agreement (FTA) is expected to be operational next month even as a large team of negotiators from Canada is in New Delhi, negotiating with their Indian counterparts.

India and Canada have already finalised two chapters of their proposed a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), the commerce secretary said. India and the European Union expect to sign an FTA deal by the year end or even earlier, he added.

Trusts may urge Tata Sons to seek RBI review

Varun Sood & Satish John

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MUMBAI: Tata Trusts want Tata Sons to explore all options, including asking the Reserve Bank of India to reconsider and clarify its decision directing it to go public, before taking legal recourse, two group executives aware of the plans said.

The central bank is understood to have filed a caveat in the Bombay high court on Monday to ensure its position is heard before any judicial order on the public listing of Tata Sons, which could mark the start of a protracted legal tussle between the central bank and India's largest conglomerate. The decision follows RBI's Saturday letter rejecting Tata Sons' request to surrender its registration, which would force it to proceed with a public share sale.

Since Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata and most trustees desire to keep Tata Sons private, the holding company could seek court intervention, Mint reported on 12 September.

"Is it a battle drawn?" quipped a Tata Group executive when asked about RBI filing a caveat, suggesting it is prepared to fight a potential legal suit from the Tata Group.



RBI caveat could mark start of a long legal tussle between it and Tata Group. MINT

"We will do everything it takes. For now, the legal route is the only option. But before that, Tata Trusts wants Tata Sons to ask the RBI to reconsider its decision and clarify why it rejected its plea. Then they will take the legal route. All this is expected to be discussed in the board meeting," said the executive, referring to Tata Sons' board meeting on 17 September.

The meeting will be the first since N. Chandrasekaran on 12 August said he will not seek a third term at the conglomerate's helm. It is unclear whether the Tata Sons board, led by Chandrasekaran, will support its main shareholder Tata Trusts in challenging the RBI order or go against it, the second executive

said. This is because two trustees—Venu Srinivasan and retired defence secretary Vijay Singh—have changed their earlier position, and now support listing Tata Sons. Singh was removed from the Tata Sons board last September, while Srinivasan remains one of the Trusts' two nominees. Besides Chandrasekaran, Noel and Srinivasan, the Tata Sons board includes group CFO Saurabh Agrawal and independent directors Harish Manwani and Anita Marangoly George.

According to the three top Tata executives, while some of Noel Tata's opponents have proactively filed complaints while remaining trustees, the Tata Trusts chairman has typically reacted to such moves since taking over in October 2024.

A few months ago, Singh filed a complaint against a smaller Tata trust linked to Sir Ratan Tata Trusts (SRTT), accusing it of wrongdoing. Srinivasan also complained that the number of permanent members at SRTT is breach of rules. These complaints caused the Maharashtra charity commissioner to stop SRTT from holding board meetings or making official decisions. Former trustee Mehli Mistry too has filed multiple challenges against Tata Trusts.

SENSEX, NIFTY TANK OVER 1%; IT STOCKS SURGE

MUMBAI: Benchmark Sensex tanked 778 points while the broader stock index Nifty closed at a five-month low on Tuesday amid surging oil prices, geopolitical tensions and weak trends in global markets.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 777.94 points, or 1.04%, to settle at a three-month low of 74,003.82, dragged by losses in blue-chip banking, auto and oil & gas shares.

The index opened higher but lost steam in late-morning deals as selling gathered pace. The barometer later tanked 787.73 points, or 1.05%, to a day's low of 73,994.03.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 279.50 points, or 1.19%, to end at 23,118.60, the lowest closing level since April 6.

Meanwhile, IT stocks emerged as the key outperformers in an otherwise bearish equity market. IT stocks surged, with HCL Tech, Hexaware and Infosys ending nearly 4% higher in a weak broader market as comments suggesting slower AI development eased concerns over the rapid disruption of traditional IT services.

Shares of HCL Technologies jumped 3.98%, Hexaware Technologies surged 3.97%, Infosys climbed 3.61%, Tech Mahindra was up 2.31%, TCS rallied 2.18% and Wipro edged higher by 1.40% on the BSE. PTI

SC UPHOLDS SANCTION AGAINST NSE'S CHITRA RAMAKRISHNA

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday refused to interfere with the sanction granted for the prosecution of former National Stock Exchange (NSE) managing director and CEO Chitra Ramakrishna under the Prevention of Corruption Act in the NSE co-location case, while allowing her to raise before the trial court the question of whether she was performing a "public duty" and could be treated as a public servant.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran disposed of Ramakrishna's challenge to a Delhi high court order upholding the sanction, saying the issue of whether she was performing a public duty could be raised during the trial.

The Delhi high court in July, held that the NSE performs a public duty because of its vital role in the economy and financial markets, and that Ramakrishna, by virtue of her position as its managing director and CEO, could not be completely separated from the functions discharged by the exchange. The high court had accordingly rejected her plea to quash the sanction granted by the NSE board for her prosecution under the PC Act. It also held that whether Ramakrishna was actually in charge of the NSE's day-to-day functioning and policy decisions, including the acts or contracts referred to in the charge sheet, were matters to be established through evidence at trial.

ORACLE BEGINS FRESH JOB CUTS AS A PART OF RESTRUCTURING

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NEW DELHI: Oracle has begun a fresh round of job cuts as part of a broader restructuring, where affected employees were reportedly informed on September 14 that their roles were being axed.

The latest reductions come after Oracle's global workforce fell by about 21,000, or 13%, during fiscal 2026, even as the software giant's spending on data centres and other infrastructure to support its AI and cloud ambitions has spiked.

The US-based tech giant - which has a significant India footprint, including product engineering teams, support functions and development teams - recently raised the estimated cost of its restructuring programme by \$700 million to about \$2.8 billion, a plan that includes employee severance and contract terminations.

The number of global employees affected in the latest round has not been disclosed.

Industry watchers, however, fear India could be hit hard by Oracle's latest round of layoffs, with some media reports pegging the impact in thousands.

Rapido faces ₹10 lakh fine over fare nudges

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NEW DELHI: Ride-booking apps that prompt users to pay more -- with messages such as "Captains aren't accepting at ₹x. Try adding +10, +20, +30" appearing while the app is still searching for a driver-- will now have to stop using such nudges.

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has now said that such prompts put pressure on consumers to pay more at the very moment they were waiting for their ride to be confirmed.

The authority imposed a ₹1 million penalty on Roppen Transportation Services Pvt Ltd, which operates Rapido, and directed the company to stop using the prompts and other interface designs that could steer riders towards higher payments.

The order, dated August 31, 2026, found Rapido guilty of misleading advertising, unfair trade practice, unfair contract and use of dark patterns -- design features that manipulate or influence a consumer's choice.

In a representation dated May 16, a user alleged that app-based

taxi aggregator had introduced a feature prompting users to pay a "tip" to the driver before confirmation of the ride, on the representation that doing so would expedite the booking process, and further alleged arbitrary and excessive pricing during peak hours in the absence of any statutory fare regulation applicable to private cab aggregators.

The CCPA in its investigation observed that the application was in fact displaying prompts such as "Higher the price, higher the chance of getting a ride" and "Captains aren't accepting at ₹60. Try adding +10, +20, +30."

That, the CCPA said, created the impression that the rider's chances of getting a ride depended on paying more, even though the company had not produced data showing that an additional payment actually increased the likelihood of a ride being confirmed. This, the authority classified as "Confirm Shaming", one of the dark patterns identified under the government's 2023 guidelines.

Simply said, the CCPA's objection was that the app was making the consumer feel that refusing to pay more could mean losing the ride or waiting longer.

Jobless rate falls to 5% in August

Abhishek Jha

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NEW DELHI: India's headline unemployment rate came in at 5% in August, marginally lower than the 5.1% figure in August last year, but rose by half a percentage point for the younger 15-29 years age group to 15.1%. This makes August at least the fourth consecutive month when the headline unemployment rate fell compared to the previous year and at least the fifth consecutive month when the youth unemployment rate rose.

These numbers are from the

monthly bulletin of the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) published by the National Statistics Office (NSO) on Tuesday. Since monthly bulletins are available only from April 2025, year-on-year trends can only be tracked from April 2026. Youth unemployment rose year-on-year (y-o-y) every month in this period, while overall unemployment rate fell marginally from May. Labour market indicators are generally compared y-o-y to account for seasonality of some jobs, such as those in agriculture.

To be sure, bump in youth

unemployment rate in August was slower compared to earlier. The 15-29 age group's unemployment rate rose by 1.5 percentage points in April (partly due to a low base), but by 0.9 percentage points in the next two months, 0.7 percentage points in July, and 0.5 percentage points in August. The slow growth in unemployment was not due to a base effect. On the other hand, the headline unemployment rate fell year-on-year by a consistent 10 basis points -- one basis point is one hundredth of a percentage point -- every month from May onwards.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

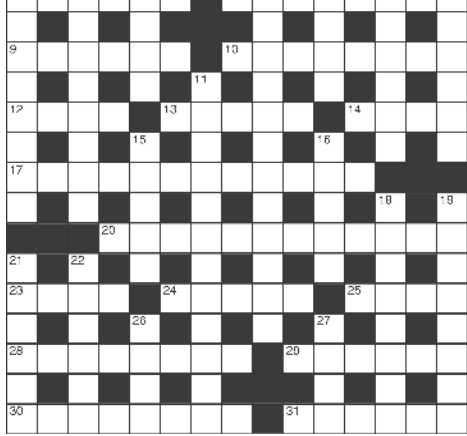
- 1 Fellows gather round to help a girl (6)
- 4 Put out an account with wrong rebate (8)
- 9 Concentrate on providing a great range (6)
- 10 An automatic grill should do it for you (8)
- 12 It's unusual not to be well done (4)
- 13 One can be accused of taking offence (5)
- 14 Small price to pay for some music (4)
- 17 Form that saves time for the writer (12)
- 20 An editor sits out a formal discourse (12)
- 23 Concluded no more is remaining (4)
- 24 Just a hint of personal contact (5)
- 25 Some leg of beef (4)
- 28 Rides out perhaps but is unlikely to win (8)
- 29 Dog in the street going mad (6)
- 30 Misplaced trust in a nudist (8)
- 31 Orders a transfer of credits without right (6)

DOWN

- 1 Something to remind one in passing (8)
- 2 Conceive dedication in a writer (8)
- 3 No good, demonstrably vile (4)
- 5 Today's charge for electricity (7,5)
- 6 Squabbles can get endlessly worse (4)
- 7 Man attached to a girl (6)
- 8 To occupy oneself go into battle (6)
- 11 Are they bound to come to light continuously? (5,7)
- 15 Lived up to a bad name (5)
- 16 Common clothes wrapped round a Roman (5)
- 18 Huge fantastic figure put on a two-wheeled carriage (8)
- 19 All the same they suit some people (8)
- 21 Two companies joining together on a silk product (6)
- 22 Small group involved in PE test (6)
- 26 Outstanding coastal feature (4)
- 27 Go ahead with the roof covering (4)

PUZZLE 17592

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 Speak indistinctly (6)
- 4 Limited to a small circle (8)
- 9 Remote technical terminology (6)
- 10 Belonging to earliest times (8)
- 12 Bias in information (4)
- 13 Over-sentimental (5)
- 14 More precisely (4)
- 17 Choleric (2,1,3,6)
- 20 No alternative (7,3,2)
- 23 Eager (4)
- 24 Take great pleasure (5)
- 25 Feigned (4)
- 28 Given to delay (8)
- 29 Wander idly (6)
- 30 Kingdom (8)
- 31 Casual (6)

DOWN

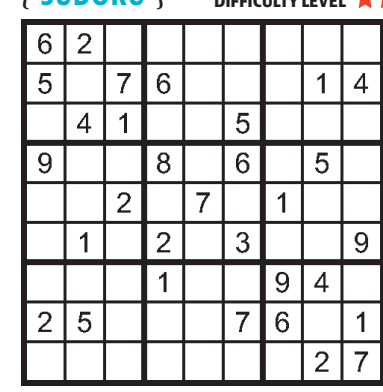
- 1 Stately and dignified (8)
- 2 Paste of ground almonds (8)
- 3 Weaving machine (4)
- 5 Iron-willed (6-6)
- 6 Domesticated (4)
- 7 Put new life into (6)
- 8 Group of settlers (6)
- 11 Be very expensive (4,3,5)
- 15 General destruction (5)
- 16 Regard as a god (5)
- 18 Forbid (8)
- 19 Sudden rush in panic (8)
- 21 Haphazard (6)
- 22 Stringed instrument (6)
- 26 Sensation (4)
- 27 Become uninteresting (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17591)

CRYPTIC
N I C H E S T A Y I N G
U O L P T L U
O A N I F O O T H I L L S
L D I T I L L S
E T E R N A L E N J O Y
A N N E S T U
R E S U M E T E N N I S
E I D E A R P L U G
M O D E L N O E H
R E S T R A I N T L O T
A E I E O A E
L E A N D E R R O W E D

QUICK
O N S E T P O L I T I C
L O R O A I A
Y E T A D N A U S E A M
M T C D N E
P R O T E G E D R I L L
U V
S P O N G E P R E S T O
C E U O B
S T E R N R E S T F U L
E B E A I
E N P A S S A N T C O G
L E I N U T E
F I N E I S I E P R O U D

{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■ HIGH ■ LOW

WEDNESDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain

THURSDAY
Partly cloudy sky

FRIDAY
Partly cloudy sky

33°C | 22°C

32°C | 21°C

32°C | 21°C

ALMANAC

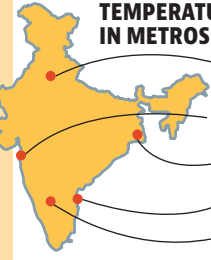
Today is

16th September 2026

• 3 Rabi Al-Akhar, M48
• 21 Bhadrapada, Shukla
Paksha, 06
• Samvat 2083

• Sunrise: Wednesday
at 06:20 p.m.
• Sunset: Thursday
at 06:08 a.m.

• Moonrise: Wednesday
at 10:23 p.m.
• Moonset: Wednesday
at 09:57 p.m.



TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi

34°C | 24°C

Mumbai

32°C | 26°C

Kolkata

33°C | 26°C

Chennai

34°C | 27°C

Bengaluru

23°C | 22°C

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



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A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

In Samarkand, star-studded India have crowns to defend

Susan Ninan

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BENGALURU: Being the team to beat is an odd burden in sport. India will carry it to the Fide Chess Olympiad, which begins in Samarkand, Uzbekistan on Wednesday, along with a line-up that makes the 'defending champion' tag feel both deserved and demanding.

The Open team, seeded second behind the USA, is packed with star players: reigning world champion D Gukesh, the year's most impressive player R Praggnanandhaa, the chaotic, creative genius Arjun Erigaisi, Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi.

The top-seeded women's team will have Women's World Championship challenger Vaishali R, reigning World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh, two-time world rapid champion Koneru Humpy, as well as Vantika Agrawal and Savitha Shri Baskar.

"In the pre-2700-2750 rated Indian team, it was not required to have a huge level of secrecy because players were not facing each other at high-stakes events. But once that happened, we couldn't discuss openings and certain things as freely as we could have when they were at a slightly lower level."

Things were especially tough in the 2023 Asian Games, Narayanan revealed. "The tension between the players was at its peak then because it was the first time that we had teammates being rivals with each other directly and the Candidates cycle was ending in just a few months from then."

Narayanan said, they came up with a system of having one coach per player to maintain privacy in preparation.

The US will start as the Open top seed by rating in the 11-round classical tournament ahead of defending champions India and hosts Uzbekistan. Uzbekistan have World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov and Nodirbek Abdusattorov, leading their line-up.

Then, there's the tiny matter of the board order. With four players making up one team, where each player sits can matter. The challenge is to get the strategy and order right and make the most of

CHESS OLYMPIAD 2026

The pinnacle of team glory in chess

India, the defending Open and women's champions, will bid to repeat their double in 2024 Budapest

400 TOTAL TEAMS | **208** TEAMS IN THE OPEN | **192** TEAMS IN THE WOMEN'S EVENT

The figure better the previous record of 380 teams at the 2024 Budapest edition

TOP TEAMS IN OPEN

Average Elo rating

1 USA	2753
2 INDIA	2735
3 Uzbekistan	2720
4 China	2707
5 Germany	2677

TOP TEAMS IN WOMEN

Average Elo rating

1 INDIA	2466
2 Georgia	2451
3 Kazakhstan	2438
4 China	2429
5 USA	2415

INDIA TEAM

PLAYER	ELO
R Praggnanandhaa	2761
Arjun Erigaisi	2759
Nihal Sarin	2718
D Gukesh	2703
Vidit Gujrathi	2697



Captain: Srinath Narayanan

INDIA TEAM

PLAYER	ELO
Koneru Humpy	2509
Divya Deshmukh	2490
Vaishali Rameshbabu	2469
IM Vantika Agrawal	2395
IM Savitha Shri	2382



Captain: Swayams Mishra

FROM: SEPTEMBER 16 TO 27, AT SAMARKAND, UZBEKISTAN

what each player brings. It is likely that the top two boards could be between Praggnanandhaa and Gukesh with Arjun on Board 3 and Nihal on Board 4 in the Open section. "What I look at is, where a player can exert maximum pressure," Narayanan said.

In the women's section, Vaishali and Divya could take up the top two boards with Humpy on the third board and Vantika on Board 4. For Gukesh, who has been struggling with form, the Olympiad is his final tournament appearance before the World Championship in November. "He's been pretty chill in the last couple of months, not as serious and

intense as he was earlier. He's been playing some turf cricket and picking up a hobby or two," Narayanan said.

Team stranded for hours

It's not been a great start so far to the Samarkand Olympiad with national teams being stranded without rooms for hours together after landing in the Uzbek city. Indian Open team captain Srinath Narayanan wrote on X: "Having a terrible experience at the Olympiad. The team landed 5 hours ago at Samarkand airport. The team still haven't been allotted hotel rooms, with absolutely no clarity on when it'll be allotted."

"37 hours awake, 2 flights, half way around the world only to be told, you don't have a hotel room that night, typical Olympiad," Jonathan Blackburn, Welsh team member, wrote on X.

It's a terrible indictment of the local organisers that national teams should have to go through this on the eve of the tournament. "...appalling stories about teams being placed in dormitories with shared toilets. Some rooms have no internet. Some teams have to leave before 1 pm to play a 3pm game because they are placed that far away," Singapore Chess Federation CEO Kevin Goh Wei Ming, wrote on X.

While the Indian players were allotted rooms after a long wait, coaches have been forced to share rooms until individual rooms are provided.

Incidentally, in the opening press conference on Tuesday, when Uzbek star Abdusattorov was asked about his most memorable Olympiad experience, he singled out the 2022 Chennai Olympiad. "I think conditions are incredibly important for players. It directly impacts your confidence, mood and results. In Chennai, we had an amazing time and it was part of our success."

Uzbekistan won the gold medal in the Open section in that edition.

Afghanistan T20I: Samson has his say, India seal series

Samreen Razzaqui

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NEW DELHI: Mohammad Nabi has been around the T20 set-up for a long, long time — 16 years, to be precise. But seniority counts for little when Abhishek Sharma and Sanju Samson get going.

Chasing 160, the explosive opening duo stitched an 88-run partnership that was pivotal in India's seven-wicket win over Afghanistan in the second T20I at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Tuesday. Shreyas Iyer and Co took an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series. Afghanistan, after a shaky start, scored 159/8 and India reached 163/3 in 14.5 overs.

The opening pair closed in on a dominant Powerplay — India had already scored 55 runs in the first five overs. They took apart Nabi's off-spin for 27 runs in the sixth over, taking India to a staggering 82/0 after the PowerPlay.

Rashid Khan did not fare too well either bowling the seventh over. Abhishek and Samson plundered 17 runs. If Abhishek (39 in 19 balls) doesn't get you, Samson (57 off 22 balls) will. And if both are denied, there is always Ishan Kishore (38* off 23) in the wings.

After both openers were dis-



Sanju Samson celebrates after reaching his fifty. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

missed in the seventh over, Kishan took over. Kishan combined with Tilak Varma, stitching an unbeaten 40-run stand to chase the total with 5.1 overs left.

For Afghanistan, a familiar collapse unfolded after being asked to bat. They managed to hold firm through the Powerplay, but then lost three wickets in three overs to slump to 67/4 after 10.1 overs.

The numbers underline the extent of Afghanistan's batting struggles. Their combined Powerplay score of 82/5 (41/4 & 41/1) across the two matches was what India scored in each of their Powerplays. Ibrahim Zadran was the only member of their top four to

make a substantial contribution.

In the first game, it was Azmatullah Omarzai and Nabi who rescued the innings, registering a 83-run stand to help Afghanistan scrape past 150. This time, Nabi and Rashid took charge of the recovery, putting together a 48-run partnership. However, against this fiery Indian batting line-up and the short boundaries, after Jasprit Bumrah started with a maiden over, it was hardly going to be enough.

Brief scores: 159/8 (I Zadran 37, Nitish Reddy 3/24). India 163/3 in 14.5 overs (S Samson 57, Abhishek Sharma 39, Rashid Khan 3/36). **India won by 7 wickets.**

TASK FORCE TO ASSESS F1 REVIVAL IN INDIA NAMED

Press Trust of India

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Sports minister Manu Singh Mandaviya named a task force to assess the challenges and feasibility of reviving F1 in India under the chairmanship of Niti Aayog director and adviser Yugal Kishore Joshi.

The 10-member committee also features joint secretary (sports) Kunal besides FMSCI president Arindam Ghosh. The task force also has representation from the department of tourism and commerce among others and will include representatives from Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra government.

India last hosted a F1 race in 2013. It was dropped due to bureaucratic and taxation issues.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

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Awards in memory of Randhir, Rana

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: IOA president PT Usha announced two awards in the memory of Randhir Singh and Jaspal Rana, the two shooting stalwarts who passed away this year.

The Raja Randhir Singh Memorial Trophy will be pre-

sented to the best Indian male athlete of the Asian Games, while the Jaspal Rana Memorial Trophy will go to the best female athlete of the Games.

"I believe this is a fitting way to remember these two extraordinary men. Jaspal devoted himself to developing new champions, Raja ji devoted his life to serving the Olympic movement. Both

understood what it meant to wear the Indian colours and represent our country on the biggest stage of sports, and now their names will travel with our athletes into the future," Usha said. Singh, a five-time Olympian and the first Indian shooter to win an Asian Games gold, was a longtime administrator and served in various capacities in IOA and OCA.

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Nairobi to host 2029 world athletics

PARIS: Nairobi will host the 2029 world athletics championships, beating off competition from London, Munich and Rome to become the first African hosts, World Athletics announced. The 2031 championships will be held in Munich, WA said after a council meeting in Budapest.

Davis Cup: Yuki out of India-Korea tie

SEOUL: India will be without their key doubles player Yuki Bhambri in their Davis Cup Qualifier against South Korea after the veteran was ruled out with a thigh injury. The winner of this match will advance into the finals.

Champions League final set for Munich

PARIS: The 2028 Champions League final will be held at the Allianz Arena in Munich and the 2029 final will take place at the Camp Nou, UEFA announced. Spain will thus once again take centre stage, just two years after the 2027 final, which is scheduled to take place at Metropolitano in Madrid.

HI executive board meeting on Sept 18

NEW DELHI: Hockey India has called an emergency executive board meeting on Sept 18 to resolve the differences among its top officials and restructure the struggling Hockey India League to create a Governing Council. HI president Dilip Tirkey and secretary Bhola Nath Singh have not been on the same page for a while.

Kalkal wins trials for World C'ships

LUCKNOW: Sajeet Kalkal won in the 65kg freestyle at selection trials. Yash, Sachin, and Abhimanyu also secured top finishes in their respective weight divisions, setting up a final trial showdown with the Asian Games-bound contingent for berths at the Worlds.

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